

Govt approves plan to replace old trucks, buses with EVs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has approved the proposal to implement and support the Union Ministry of Road Transport and Highway's scheme for reducing vehicular emissions in the national capital. According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, this scheme aims to phase out old, polluting trucks and buses and replace them with BS-VI, higher-emission-standard or electric vehicles, thereby reducing transport-related air pollution and emissions. The Programme for Accelerated Renewal and

Incentivisation of Vehicle Assets for Reducing Transport Air Pollution and Network Emissions (PARIVARTAN) aims to phase out old, polluting trucks and buses and replace them with BS-VI, higher-emission-standard or electric vehicles, thereby reducing transport-related air pollution and emissions. The chief minister said, "The scheme marks an important step towards replacing old, highly polluting trucks and buses in Delhi-NCR with BS-VI, higher-emission-standard or electric vehicles. It will strengthen the capital's clean transport system while helping

modernise the commercial vehicle fleet and reduce air pollution." The Chief Minister said that under the scheme, owners of BS-IV or older Light Goods Vehicles (LGVs) who scrap their vehicles and purchase a new electric LGV will receive a 100 per cent exemption on motor vehicle tax and registration fees for 10 years from the Delhi Government. They will also be eligible for a 5 per cent interest subvention, an 8 per cent discount from the vehicle manufacturer (OEM), and fuel vouchers or a one-time benefit equivalent to the discounted value of the fuel vouchers. If, instead of pur-



chasing a new electric LGV, the owner buys a used electric LGV, the beneficiary will receive a 50 per cent exemption on motor vehicle tax for 10 years, a 5 per cent interest subvention, and a one-time benefit equivalent to the discounted value of the fuel vouchers. The scheme also covers Medium Goods Vehicles (MGVs) and Heavy Goods Vehicles (HGVs) that are BS-IV or older. Owners who scrap such vehicles and purchase new BS-VI, higher-emission-standard or electric goods vehicles will be eligible for a 100 per cent exemption on motor vehicle tax for 10 years,

a 100 per cent waiver of registration fees, a 5 per cent interest subvention, an 8 per cent OEM discount, and fuel vouchers or a one-time benefit equivalent to the discounted value of the fuel vouchers. If a used BS-VI or electric goods vehicle is purchased instead of a new one, the beneficiary will receive a 50 per cent exemption on motor vehicle tax for 10 years, a 5 per cent interest subvention, and a one-time benefit equivalent to the discounted value of the fuel vouchers. According to the government, the scheme is expected to benefit around 2.07

lakh truck and bus owners in the Delhi-NCR. "It will replace a large number of old, highly polluting commercial vehicles with cleaner and more modern ones, leading to a reduction in air pollution. The Delhi Government is fully committed to promoting clean transport. Keeping this objective in mind, the scheme provides that all LGVs purchased in Delhi under the scheme must be electric. For buses, only BS-VI CNG or electric (EV) vehicles will be permitted," the chief minister said. She added that the scheme will further strengthen the objectives of the Delhi EV Policy-2026.

LG chairs DDMA meet, stresses no flooding, fix responsibility for failures

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday chaired a meeting of the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) on the city government's monsoon preparedness and stressed that all necessary steps be taken to ensure there is minimal or no flooding at all in the city. He also called for the fixing of responsibility for failures of duties.

The meeting was attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, cabinet ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh and Ashish Sood as well as top officers of various departments and agencies, officials at the LG office said.

The chief minister also stressed that no drain, sewer line or manhole should be left uncovered and any potholes or ditches should be levelled immediately. She underlined zero tolerance for any accident on these accounts.

As a preventive measure, the issue of the removal of dangerous trees that often fall during storms or heavy rainfall was also discussed in the meeting. It was underlined that action to this effect should be proactive rather than as a reaction to tragic accidents.

Raising serious concerns, the chief minister directed that such trees be identified and removed on a priority basis to prevent any loss of life, the officials said.

Lieutenant Governor Sandhu as well as Chief Minister Gupta said that there should be no delay in resolving any flooding or accident-related



issues on account of jurisdictional divisions between the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), New Delhi Municipal Corporation (NDMC) and the Public Works Department (PWD), and called for quick and coordinated resolution regardless of the agency under which the site falls.

In the meeting, Sandhu expressed satisfaction that waterlogging sites in the city declined from 194 in 2024 to 169 in 2025, and remarkably reduced to just 34 till now in 2026, the officials said. Both the LG and the chief minister directed deployment of mobile heavy-duty pumps, real-time public feedback and on-ground situation monitoring, besides coordination with the neighbouring states to strengthen the capital's disaster response mechanism, they said.

At the outset, the LG as well as Gupta observed that there was much scope for improvement even though there had been a significant improvement in the flooding situation in the city in comparison to

2024 and 2025, the officials said. Emphasising that Met predictions indicated spells of heavy and sudden rainfall, Sandhu underlined that all steps must be undertaken to ensure that there is minimal or no flooding at all. He cautioned that accountability in this regard was of extreme importance and responsibility for failures will be fixed, they said.

The LG reiterated that although flooding was largely a legacy issue in the city, officials should enforce all measures to tackle it in the short-term, even as the long-term drainage master plan is being implemented. Officials informed in the meeting that the MCD, Irrigation and Flood Control Department and the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) had achieved their target of de-silting of drains. The Delhi government's PWD has achieved about 95 per cent de-silting target, with the work on the remaining target being hampered by encroachments on drains under its jurisdiction, the officials said.

Delhi BJP President announces new team of office-bearers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra on Monday announced his new team of office-bearers and heads of frontal organisations, with the reshuffle placing emphasis on experienced leaders.

In a statement, Malhotra said the appointments were made after due consultation with the national leadership and with the approval of BJP national president Nitin Nabin.

Of the 38 newly appointed office-bearers, 19 were part of the outgoing Delhi BJP team, while several others have previously held organisational

responsibilities. Three presidents of the BJP's frontal organisations (morchas) from the previous team were promoted to the main state organisation, said a Delhi BJP statement.

Malhotra, who took charge as Delhi BJP president in May, has named 10 vice-presidents, three general secretaries and nine secretaries in the new team.

Senior leaders Rajesh Bhatia, Sunil Yadav, Richa Pandey Mishra, Kaushal Mishra, Vikram Bidhuri, and Sarika Jain are among the new vice-presidents of the party. Vishnu Mittal, Yogita Singh and Mohan Lal Gihara are the general secretaries.

Praveen Shankar Kapoor has



retained his post as head of the media team, while Anil Gupta has been appointed as the chief spokesperson, and Rohit Upadhyay will head the social media team.

Rajat Chaudhary has been appointed as president of the Delhi BJP Yuva Morcha, while Archana Gupta will head the

Mahila Morcha team. The other appointments include Santosh Pal as president of the OBC Morcha; Lajpat Rai as president of the SC Morcha; C.L. Meena as president of the ST Morcha; Santosh Ojha as president of the Purvanchal Morcha; Devendra Solanki as president of the Kisan Morcha; and Anees Abbas as president of the Minorities Morcha.

Malhotra said the new team reflects the party's focus on organisational experience, while maintaining a balanced representation of different regions, social groups, and a healthy mix of experienced and new workers.

NGT directs officials to resolve DDA-IFC row over Yamuna demarcation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Expressing displeasure over the stalling of the Yamuna floodplain demarcation, the National Green Tribunal has directed Delhi's Principal Secretary (Environment) to resolve the issue between the DDA and the Irrigation and Flood Control (IFC) Department.

The green body had earlier sought a progress report from the Delhi Development Authority. In an order dated July 16, made available on Monday, a bench of Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afroz Ahmad said that according to the DDA's report, the IFC



department had provided a revised map for physical demarcation in a communication dated June 6.

The bench noted that, according to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), till the date of receipt of the said communication, out of 277 bollards, 206 bollards were fixed, but after receiving the letter, the authority did not proceed with the demarca-

tion work. It noted the DDA's submission that if the communication is required to be acted upon, then a refixing of bollards may be required.

Expressing displeasure, the tribunal said that the demarcation of the floodplain of the river Yamuna in the given stretch of Delhi is to be carried out in terms of the River Ganga (Rejuvenation, Protection and Management) Authorities Order, 2016.

It said that the parameters for demarcation, such as a one-meter contour with a 1:100-year flood level, had been fixed, and if following those parameters, the demarcation had started, then the IFC department needed to explain why "in the

middle of that exercise a revised map is sent".

"Since the entire work of demarcation of the floodplain is held up because of the said communication, we require the Principal Secretary, Environment (Delhi government) to hold a joint meeting of the officials of the DDA and IFC department within one week," the tribunal said.

The NGT further directed the IFC department to file an affidavit explaining why a revised map was sent in the middle of an ongoing exercise.

The DDA has also been directed to file a fresh progress report at least one week before the next date of hearing (on September 18).

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Poonam, W/o No.4202467M Hav Pushpendra Kumar, R/o- Vill- Baramai, Post- Sikandra Rao, Dist- Hathras, U.P.- 204215, have changed my name from Poonam to Poonam Devi, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(218)C I, No.15455945K Sep Gali Guruswamy, R/o- Door No. 1-162, Vill- Jeedipalli, PO- Ankampalli, Teh- Beluguppa, Dist- Anantpur, A.P.- 515741, have changed my father's name in my service record from Gali Chinnu Akkulanna to Gali Akullanna, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(213)C I, Nilina Barman, Mother of No.16022048W Nk Lankeswar Barman, R/o- Vill & PO- Bartala, Dist- Nalbari, Assam, have changed my name from Nilina Barman to Nilima Barman, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(214)C I, No.15440218P Nk Lute Nilesh Bhagwan, R/o- At-Pokhari, Post- Wadod Tangda, Teh- Bhokardan, Dist- Jalna, Maharashtra- 431132, have changed my Mother's name in my service record from Dwarka to Dwarkabai Bhagwan Lute, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(215)C I, Seshei Tuboi, Father of No.23001955X LNK Ngullenmang Tuboi, R/o- Ward No. 6, Keithelmanboi, PO- Kalapahar, Dist/ P.S- Kangpokpi, Manipur- 795122 have changed my name from Seshei Tuboi to Sehsei Tuboi, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(216)C I, No.15587324N Nk Ashok R/o- Vill- Bodani, PO- Patlawada, Teh&Dist- Dewas, M.P.- 455001, have changed my daughter's name from Tanvi Rathod to Tanvi, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(217)C

I, Saroj, Mother of No.10136987N Rfn Vijay, R/o- K-1265, Mangolpuri, Delhi- 110083, have changed my name from Saroj to Saroj Devi, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(218)C I, No.15455945K Sep Gali Guruswamy, R/o- Door No. 1-162, Vill- Jeedipalli, PO- Ankampalli, Teh- Beluguppa, Dist- Anantpur, A.P.- 515741, have changed my father's name in my service record from Gali Chinnu Akkulanna to Gali Akullanna, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(219)C I Krishna, spouse of No.6923183P Ex-Hav Suresh Kumar R/o H.No.323, Uttam Vihar, Rothak, Haryana, have changed my name from Krishna to Krishna Devi vide Affidavit dated 16/07/2026 Before Executive Magistrate Rohtak.

PD(220)C I, No.15455945K Sep Gali Guruswamy, R/o- Door No. 1-162, Vill- Jeedipalli, PO- Ankampalli, Teh- Beluguppa, Dist- Anantpur, A.P.- 515741, have changed my mother's name in my service record from Gali Ramadevi to Gali Ramdevi, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(221)C I, No.14679718W Nk Vivek Kumar Shukla, R/o- Vill- Sirawat, PO- Udairajganj, Dist- Siddharthnagar, U.P.- 272204, have changed my son's name from Arush Shukla to Aarush Shukla, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(222)C

I, Bhavna Shukla, W/o No.14679718W Nk Vivek Kumar Shukla, R/o- Vill- Sirawat, PO- Udairajganj, Dist- Siddharthnagar, U.P.- 272204, have changed my name from Bhavna Shukla to Bhavna Tiwari, vide affidavit dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(223)C I, No.15343567P Hav Dharmendra Singh R/o- Vill- Bantikula Sihorwa, Dist- Gorakhpur, U.P.- 273007, declare that in my service record my Son's D.O.B is wrongly written as 03/04/2011 whereas correct D.O.B is 03/04/2013 vide affidavit No. IN-DL57993652936149Y dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(224)C I, Pandurang, F/o No.15208339Y Hav (GNR) Gherade Bramhadeo Pandurang, R/o- Vill- Kidebisari, PO- Nagaj, PS & Teh- Sangola, Distt- Solapur, Maharashtra- 416403, have changed my name from Pandurang to Pandurang Mahadev Gherade, vide Affidavit No. IN-DL57994293878949Y, dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(225)C I, No.15208339Y Hav (GNR) Gherade Bramhadeo Pandurang, R/o- Vill- Kidebisari, PO- Nagaj, PS & Teh- Sangola, Distt- Solapur, Maharashtra- 416403, have changed my son's name from Pratik Bramhadeo Gherade to Pratik Bramhadeo Gherade, vide Affidavit No. IN-DL57995911533785Y, dated 20/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(226)C

I, Mamtabai Pandurang Gheradeo, M/o- No.15208339Y Hav (GNR) Gherade Bramhadeo Pandurang, R/o- Vill- Kidebisari, PO- Nagaj, PS & Teh- Sangola, Distt- Solapur, Maharashtra- 416403, have changed my name from Mamtabai Pandurang Gheradeo to Mamtabai Pandurang Gherade, vide Affidavit No. IN-DL57997148029179Y,

PD(227)C I, Tushar Sharma S/o Late Vinod Kumar Sharma R/o B-3703, Saviour Park, Loni Road, Mohan Nagar, Distt Ghaziabad U.P. declare that Vinod Kumar Sharma, Vinod Sharma and Vinod Kumar is one and same person. My father's correct name is Vinod Kumar Sharma for all future purposes and records.

PD(228)C I, Rajesh Kumar, S/o Shatrughan Sharma, R/o Kh. No.-20, Gali No.-8, Shivam Enclave, Village-Noor Nagar, Ghaziabad (U.P) 201007 have changed my name from Rajesh Kumar to Rajesh Kumar Vishvkarma. Henceforth, I would be known by the name of Rajesh Kumar Vishvkarma for all purposes.

PD(229)C I, Komal D/o Harish Chandra Residing at A-40, Gali No-6, East Vinod Nagar, Delhi-110091, have changed my name from Komal Fulara for all future purposes.

PD(244)C I, Kumari Ravina W/o Bhuban Singh, Residing at A/43, Gali No-4, East Vinod Nagar, Delhi-110091, have changed my name from Kumari Ravina to Ravina Devi for all future purposes.

PD(245)C

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Last date for submission duly filled application form in the Institute alongwith with the Registration Fees of Rs. 2,500/- (Non-refundable) is 31st July, 2026 (3:00 pm). *Statutory Reservation as per Govt. Policy Applicable.

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Open Tender No.	ELS-SRE-26-27-T-2
Name of Work	Installation of LED-Based Signal Exchange Control Units and Lamp Units, and repainting of hydraulic jacks at Electric Loco Shed Saharanpur.
Date of Closing/Opening	12.08.2026
Approx. Cost	₹18,57,360/-
Earnest Money	₹37,200/-
Completion period	Eighteen (18) Months
Validity period	60 days
Cost of tender form	"Free of Cost" for downloading from IREPS & ₹2000 for obtaining from Sr. DEE/TRS/SRE office.

- Tenderer(s) should have Class-III Digital Signature Certificate to participate in E-Tendering of Works Tenders.
- Tenderer are required to upload self-attested scanned copies of all related eligibility documents as per conditions.
- Taxes & Charges will be applicable as per extant rule.
- For details, please log on IREPS website www.irops.gov.in

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E-AUCTION

SALE NOTICE

(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the **Physical / Symbolic Possession** of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of Central Bank of India, secured creditors, will be sold on **28.08.2026 "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is"** basis for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in: www.centralbank.bank.in or (<https://BAANKNET.com>)

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES TO BE AUCTIONED ON 28.08.2026 (30 DAYS NOTICE)

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/ B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (Rs. in Lakhs)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Delhi Cantonment New Delhi	Mr. Suraj Kumar MOB: 8957330934	Mr. Suresh Kumar S/o Mr. Shiv Dayal and Mrs. Raj Bala W/o Mr. Suresh Kumar	All the parts and parcel of property consisting of Flat on 3rd Floor without Roof Rights area measuring 61 Sq.Yds., built on Property Bearing House No.H-2/162C, Out of Khasra No.79/12 Main Futa Road, Mahavir Enclave Palam New Delhi. Owner: Mr. Suresh Kumar S/o Mr. Shiv Dayal Mrs. Raj Bala W/o Mr. Suresh Kumar	Rs.10,97,296.08 as on 29.02.2020 + Interest + Other Charges	13.05.2026 (Symbolic)	₹ 23,50,000.00 ₹ 2,35,000.00 ₹ 20,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 28.08.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 P.M WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 28.07.2026 Upto 3:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: (<https://BAANKNET.com>) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>)).

The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider "<https://BAANKNET.com>" E-auction will be held on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).

For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in . Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>) BAANKNET Helpdesk: (+91)8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR STATUTORY 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) OF SARFAESI ACT 2002

The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 20.07.2026
PLACE: DELHI

Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA,
Regional Office (Gurugram) Chandni Chowk, Delhi

NEET protest march turns violent, tear gas and lathi charge in Capital

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

They came in the rain. They came from Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Punjab, Bihar, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Assam, and Madhya Pradesh. They came because a girl named Riya Thapa had died by suicide, because the NEET paper had leaked, and because nobody in government had resigned. They gathered at Jantar Mantar from Sunday night, slept on the wet ground, and on Monday morning, they tried to walk to Parliament. Delhi Police, which had imposed Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita across the New Delhi district, was waiting for them.

What followed was the most charged day of political protest in the capital in years. The Cockroach Janata Party's Chalo Sansad march was met with lathi charges near Parliament Street, tear gas shells near Shastri Bhawan and Raisina Road, and mass detentions across central Delhi. Internet services were suspended in parts of the city. Several entry gates to Parliament were shut. By 4 pm, repeated tear gas shelling pushed protesters past a breaking point, and the demonstration turned violent: stone-pelting began, and police vehicles were smashed near Rajiv Chowk. By evening, Jantar Mantar was completely empty, with protesters regrouped and



Security personnel fire tear gas shells to disperse CJP supporters during a protest march, near the Parliament in New Delhi Monday

gathered around Connaught Place and Rajiv Chowk. Lok Sabha was adjourned multiple times on the first day of the Monsoon Session.

The CJP launched its sit-in at Jantar Mantar on June 6, over 40 days ago. The demand throughout has been singular: the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in NEET-UG 2026. The government did not engage until Monday, the day of the march, when CJP spokesperson Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka were called in to meet BJP president JP Nadra. Das posted from outside the meeting: "Our demands are clear. The youth have gathered in huge numbers." After the meeting, he said Nadra had assured him he would speak internally, but that no commitments had been made.

The man who had held the sit-in together was not on the ground. Sonam Wangchuk,

removed from Jantar Mantar by Delhi Police on July 18 during his hunger strike and taken to Safdarjung Hospital, wrote to the hospital management on Monday morning in his own hand. The note said: "This is to state that I am feeling very fine today and my health parameters are also showing as quite normal. Hence, I kindly request that you allow me to leave the hospital, even if temporarily, so that I can join the march to Parliament. I shall be most grateful." He was not allowed to leave. The Delhi High Court, hearing a plea filed by his wife Gitanjali Angmo, directed the hospital to place his pathological reports on record.

The father of Riya Thapa, the NEET student who died by suicide, was present at Jantar Mantar and persuaded CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, who had himself been on hunger strike, to end his fast and lead the march. Dipke, addressing

supporters earlier in the day, said: "This government is not satisfied with taking the lives of 20 NEET students. They are now baying for the blood of others."

Protesters attempting to reach Jantar Mantar from Mandi House Metro Station were beaten with sticks and batons. Security forces deployed tear gas near Shastri Bhawan after protesters pushed against barricades. By 4 pm, with tear gas deployed repeatedly at multiple points, the situation at Rajiv Chowk escalated into stone-pelting and the smashing of police vehicles, marking the most violent turn in what had been a largely peaceful 40-day protest movement.

The CJP posted as the internet was cut in parts of the city: "You can shut down the internet, but how will you close the eyes and ears of the protesters who will see and report?" Delhi Police Additional CP Rajeev Ranjan appealed for calm: "Delhi Police appeals to all protesters to maintain peace, exercise restraint, and cooperate with the police."

By nightfall, the geography of the protest had shifted entirely. Jantar Mantar, where this movement had lived for 44 days, stood empty. The crowds had moved to Rajiv Chowk and the lanes around Connaught Place. The gates of Parliament remained shut. The Monsoon Session had begun with adjourned sittings and a city on edge.

Despite police crackdown, protesters continue Parliament march

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

The air around Jantar Mantar on Monday carried a mix of humidity, slogans and uncertainty. Protesters, drenched in sweat and interrupted by spells of rain, wiped their faces with scarves and flags as chants demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan echoed through central Delhi. As the afternoon wore on, the leadership of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) splintered, the planned Sansad Chalo march effectively dissolved, and negotiations began behind closed doors. Even so, the crowds on the streets showed little sign of giving up.

Rather than a single united procession towards Parliament, demonstrators gathered in smaller clusters around Janpath Metro Station Gate number 2, Jantar Mantar, and adjoining roads, raising slogans against alleged examination paper leaks and demanding sweeping education reforms from 8 am onwards. Although the day's programme unfolded far differently from what organisers had announced, the movement's supporters continued to occupy the area well into the afternoon.

The demonstration shifted dramatically after CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke ended his three-day hunger strike and spokespersons Ashutosh Ranka and Saurav Das met Union Health Minister and BJP senior leader JP Nadra for talks. CJP later said negotiations with the government



Protesters gather during a march from Jantar Mantar towards Parliament demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination in New Delhi on Monday

were underway and that it had presented its demands, effectively halting the planned Parliament march. In a separate development, AISA student leaders Neha, Ameen and Manish also ended their 23-day hunger strike after meetings with political leaders, civil society representatives and eminent personalities. Veteran actor Shabana Azmi, Rajya Sabha MP Manoj Kumar Jha and AAP leader Sanjay Singh offered them water to formally conclude their fast.

Monday morning commuters grappled with road diversions, barricades and Metro station closures, but the disruptions did little to deter those determined to register their protest. Dipke described Sunday's gathering as one of the country's largest public mobilisations in recent years. Among those in attendance was Amit, 24, a UPSC aspirant who said he had visited Jantar Mantar multiple times over the past month.

"I'm scared of my future and don't want what happened with the NEET students. This movement has given me hope, and there needs to be education overhauls," he said. Volunteers repeatedly appealed to demonstrators to remain peaceful, forming human chains to regulate entry and exit points as crowds swelled beyond expectations. However, when Delhi Police tightened barricades around the protest site to prevent marchers from advancing, the situation turned tense. Pushing and shoving broke out at several locations, and police resorted to a lathi charge to disperse sections of the crowd.

Among those caught in the chaos was Ankit, 28, from Madhya Pradesh, who had travelled to Delhi despite suffering a leg injury in a road accident 15 days ago. "I was simply finding an exit when the commotion happened, and the police struck me with the baton. I'm in

pain," he said, pointing to the bandaged leg where he claimed he had been hit.

The protest also drew many first-time participants. Unnati, a newly admitted Delhi University student, said she attended her first demonstration because of concerns about irregularities in the CUET examination. "There were delays and irregularities in our CUET examination. Fortunately, this movement is underway to hear students' problems. My classes begin next week, but I'm here to pledge my solidarity with the CJP because I want a smooth college life," she said.

As the afternoon progressed, the once-concentrated gathering splintered into smaller groups across the New Delhi district, moving well into Connaught Place. Although the CJP leaders did not formally lead the Sansad Chalo march following the negotiations, several protesters attempted to move towards Parliament on their own. Police responded with heavy deployment, baton charges and tear gas to prevent the marchers from advancing. Tear gas shells were also fired near Jantar Mantar as security forces dispersed the remaining crowds.

Nayan, a school student, alleged that police struck him while he was trying to leave the area. "I smelled the tear gas and started leaving when the police hit me," he said.

Several protesters also complained that extensive road closures across central Delhi left them stranded and struggling to find transport home.

118 police, 60 protesters injured; 70 detained as protest turns violent

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 118 police personnel sustained injuries, including senior officers of the ranks of Special Commissioner of Police, Joint Commissioner of Police, Additional Commissioner of Police, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police and Assistant Commissioner of Police, besides several women police personnel.

The scuffle, around 60 protesters were also reported to get injured. The medico-legal examination (MLC) of the remaining injured police personnel is underway. The violent mob also caused extensive damage to public property. Around 15 to 20 government vehicles, along with other government property, were vandalised during the incident. Around 70 protesters have been detained.

Appropriate legal action is being initiated, and an FIR is being registered under the relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and other applicable laws for rioting, assault on public servants, damage to public property and other offences committed during the protest. The clash erupted after CJP protesters allegedly pelted stones at security personnel near Parliament Street and other locations in the New Delhi district. Security forces responded with lathi-charges and tear gas at several points, including near Shastri Bhawan, Raisina Road, Constitution Club, and Connaught Place. Videos circulating on social media showed protesters with blood on their faces and heads, and police caning demonstrators as crowds attempted to



Security personnel stop a CJP supporter near Jantar Mantar during a protest march in New Delhi on Monday

breach multilayer barricades. Police said all videos were being verified and legal action would follow.

According to police, those detained following clashes during a protest in the national Capital were not students and their identities were being verified, even as authorities stepped up investigation into the violence.

A senior police officer requesting anonymity said the people detained in connection with the unrest were "not students at all", with their personal details and antecedents being verified by the police. The officer said Delhi Police had initiated the process of registering FIRs in connection with the clashes, damage to police vehicles and destruction of public property during the protest.

The injured police personnel and protesters were taken to hospitals for treatment. At Connaught Place, which became the final and most violent flashpoint of the day, at least three to four security force vehicles were damaged with broken windshields and shattered windows. Shops pulled shutters, tourists were asked to vacate, and the Inner and Outer Circles were effective-

ly sealed by evening.

Thousands had converged on central Delhi despite prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, which bans unlawful assemblies in the New Delhi district except at designated protest sites with prior permission.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Sachin Sharma had clarified beforehand that no permission had been sought or granted for any march. Despite this, protesters attempted repeatedly to breach barricades at multiple points, walking kilometres and regrouping through inner lanes each time they were dispersed.

Delhi Police issued multiple denials through the day. It rejected CJP allegations that Wangchuk's wife Gitanjali Angmo had been assaulted and her hair pulled: "Reports circulating on social media claiming that the wife of climate activist Sonam Wangchuk was assaulted and had her hair pulled by Delhi Police personnel are completely false and misleading." It also denied that CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke had been detained, saying he was "available on stage."

CJP protest site dismantled after Parliament march blocked, agitation to continue: Dipke

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Cockroach Janata Party's (CJP) protest camp at Jantar Mantar was dismantled by Delhi Police on Monday evening, hours after security forces blocked the party's 'Chalo Sansad' march with tear gas and baton charges, even as protesters vowed to continue their agitation until Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigns.

The stage that had become the focal point of the month-long protest, where activist Sonam Wangchuk had observed his hunger strike, was taken down by police. Trampolines, carpets, mattresses and other protest material were removed from the site, signalling the end of the physical encampment that had stood at Jantar Mantar since early June.



The police cleared the protest site at Jantar Mantar in the evening

Despite the clearance, hundreds of students and supporters regrouped at Jantar Mantar by evening. CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke addressed the gathering from a tempo fitted with loudspeakers, declaring that the movement would continue. Some stood on top of the vehicle while others raised slogans around it. The CJP leaders along with Wangchuk's

wife Geetanjali Angmo gathered near Kerala House to continue the sit-in protest.

The only people left at the site were workers clearing the area, police, and paramilitary personnel, and police vehicles stood nearby. Nearly 200 metres from the protest site, however, over 1,000 protesters remained on the road. CJP volunteers said they

Police probe viral drone footage of CJP's Parliament street protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Monday said it has launched an investigation into a viral drone video purportedly showing protesters gathered at Parliament Street, saying it is verifying the footage's authenticity and the circumstances under which the drone was operated in the high-security zone.

In a statement, the police said it had taken cognisance of the video circulating on social media and initiated a probe into the alleged unauthorised drone operation. "The authenticity of the footage and the circumstances surrounding the drone operation are being verified. Appropriate legal action will be taken for this



violation of applicable laws and drone regulations," the statement said. The footage was uploaded on the CJP's official social media pages.

A police source said the investigation launched after the footage surfaced online. The source added that the New Delhi district, which houses Parliament and several key government establishments, is a highly

sensitive security zone where prior permission is mandatory for operating drones. Any violation of the prescribed regulations attracts legal action.

Security personnel stopped the march before it could reach Parliament, leading to clashes between protesters and police. The police resorted to baton charges to disperse sections of the crowd after tensions escalated.

The viral aerial footage, which appeared to capture the scale of the protest and the subsequent police action, drew widespread social media attention, prompting authorities to examine whether the drone was flown in violation of aviation and security regulations. Police said further legal action would follow the investigation's findings.

DDA opens lifetime golf membership at Dwarka's 158-acre course from July 21

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority will open online applications for lifetime membership of its 18-hole championship golf course at Dwarka Sector 24 from Monday, July 21. The membership was opened on the directions of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, offering 850 lifetime memberships across two categories at fees ranging from Rs 3.50 lakh for government category appli-

cants to Rs 7.50 lakh for the non-government category. The applications will be open for two months.

The Dwarka Golf Course, inaugurated in 2024, has until now offered only tenure memberships for limited periods. The LG directed DDA to introduce lifetime membership with the objective of inculcating a sense of belonging to the complex among its members.

Among the 850 lifetime memberships, 250 will be available under the government category and 600



under the non-government category. In addition to lifetime membership, the existing 3-year and 5-year tenure memberships will continue

to be available. The 3-year membership is priced at Rs 1.20 lakh for the government category and Rs 2.50 lakh for the non-government cate-

gory. The 5-year membership is priced at Rs 1.80 lakh and Rs 4.50 lakh, respectively.

Applicants must apply online by paying a non-refundable registration fee of Rs 2,500. After scrutiny of applications, successful applicants will be required to deposit the full membership fee online within 30 days of receiving an offer of membership. If the number of eligible applications exceeds the available slots in any category, allotment will be made through a computerised draw of lots. Applicants are

permitted to submit only one application, as multiple applications from the same person will be rejected.

The course itself is among the most technically equipped public golf facilities in the country. Spread across 158 acres, it runs to 7,377 yards across 18 holes. The driving range extends 375 yards with 52 bays, which DDA says is the longest driving range in the country. The fairways use North Shore SLT grass, described as the first such application in India.

Commuters stranded as metro stations shut

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amit Sharma had left home an hour earlier than usual on Monday morning. He wanted to avoid the rush. When he reached the Metro station, the gates were locked. Nobody told him why. By the time he figured out another route and walked to a functioning station, he was 40 minutes behind schedule and still had not reached his office. He was not alone.

Across central Delhi on Monday, thousands of ordinary commuters, people with no connection to the CJP protest or the Parliament session, paid the price of a city that had decided to shut itself down without telling them in time.

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation shut five stations, Rajiv Chowk, Janpath, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat, and Seva Teerth, with an announcement posted on X on Monday morning. But by the time that announcement

reached most people, they were already standing at locked gates, luggage in hand, asking security personnel what was happening and getting no clear answer.

Outside Janpath station, college student Riya Verma arrived with two classmates, saw the locked gates, and stood there confused for several minutes. "We reached the station only to find the gates locked. For a few minutes, nobody knew what was happening. Now we are trying to figure out another route to reach college," she said. The three of them eventually left on foot.

At Rajiv Chowk, one of the city's busiest interchange stations, crowds built up through the morning at the closed entry and exit gates. People checked their phones, called colleagues, asked Metro staff for updates, and mostly received uncertain answers. Some climbed over barricades and locked gates to get out. Others turned around and started walking.



Commuters exit the Central Secretariat metro station after it was temporarily closed ahead of Cockroach Janata Party's (CJP) protest march in New Delhi on Monday

IN FOCUS



Devotees carrying a 1,100-metre chunadi across the Tapi River during celebrations marking the birth anniversary of the river goddess Tapi in Surat, Gujarat, Monday

Gujarat destroys seized drugs worth estimated ₹2,212 crore in Bharuch

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bharuch

Narcotics with an estimated value of ₹2,212 crore, including around 11.10 lakh bottles of various substances and 14,500 kg of drugs, seized from various parts of Gujarat over the past year, were on Monday destroyed at an incinerator in Bharuch district, officials said.

These substances were seized by local police, CID and ATS, and 877 cases were registered. The drugs were scientifically disposed of at the BEIL incinerator in the Dahej industrial area as per environmental norms in the presence of Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi, according to an official release. Sanghavi said Gujarat Police have been waging a “war” against drug cartels and peddlers by busting syndicates and coordinating with social organisations to divert youngsters away from drugs. “In every corner of Gujarat, police are acting against drug cartels and peddlers,



Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi with senior police officials and others during the launch of the Handbook on Investigation of NDPS Act Cases in Gandhinagar PTI

not as a campaign, but as a war,” he told media persons.

Sanghavi said drugs valued at more than ₹2,000 crore were destroyed at the same incineration facility last October, while the latest exercise involved narcotics valued at ₹2,212 crore. He claimed the Gujarat Police achieved the highest

conviction rate in drug-related cases in India this year.

“We have been successful in securing convictions against more than 65 per cent of those involved in spreading the drug menace. We are moving towards achieving a 100 per cent conviction rate,” he added.

Maharashtra couple found dead in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 30-year-old man and a 26-year-old woman, both natives of Maharashtra, were found dead inside a rented room in Delhi’s East of Kailash on Monday morning in an apparent case of suicide, police said.

The incident came to light after a PCR call was received at Amar Colony Police Station at 9.08 am reporting the suspected suicide of a man and a woman at Sant Nagar in East of Kailash.

When a police team reached the spot, they found that the door of the rented accommodation had already been forced open by one of the woman’s friends or neighbours after repeated attempts to contact the occupants failed. Inside the room, the 26-year-old woman, a



Nagpur resident, was found dead on the bed, while the man, identified as Anmol Kunda Patil, 30, was found hanging from the ceiling fan with a nylon rope. Police said the Crime Team and the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) examined the scene and collected evidence, police said.

A handwritten suicide note, prima facie believed to have been written by the man, was recovered and seized for forensic examination. Officials, however, did not disclose the note’s contents.

GTB fan death incident: Delhi health minister orders probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh directed officials on Monday to constitute a committee to investigate the death of a patient at Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital after a ceiling fan allegedly fell on him.

The minister said strict departmental action would be taken if negligence is found. The direction came a day after a 42-year-old patient died around three hours after a ceiling fan allegedly fell on him inside the hospital’s emergency ward, prompting his family to demand an enquiry into the incident.

During a high-level review meeting with senior Health Department officials, the minister learned that a committee headed by the Special Secretary (Health) had been constituted to investigate the incident and was asked to submit its report within three days. According to the Health Department, appropriate and strict departmental action will be taken based on the committee’s findings, reiterating that negligence in



healthcare services will not be tolerated.

In the Sunday statement, GTB Hospital said the patient died due to his existing medical condition, not because of the ceiling fan incident. It said the patient had been admitted in an unconscious condition with uncontrolled hypertension, stroke or encephalopathy complicated by aspiration pneumonia and respiratory failure.

The hospital also said a preliminary inspection found that the ceiling fan fell after its shaft fractured.

The minister chaired a review meeting to assess the preparedness of Delhi’s Government healthcare system, particularly during

the ongoing monsoon season, and discussed the issue.

During the meeting, Singh directed officials to ensure the uninterrupted availability of essential medicines, diagnostic services and healthcare infrastructure across all Government hospitals.

He instructed hospitals to maintain adequate medicine stocks and ensure essential diagnostic and laboratory services remain available without interruption so that patients receive timely treatment. The minister directed hospitals to remain fully prepared to deal with vector-borne diseases such as dengue, malaria and chikungunya. He asked officials to ensure adequate availability of medicines, testing facilities, consumables and other medical resources to manage any seasonal surge in cases.

He also reviewed vacancies in technical posts within the Health Department. He instructed officials to expedite the recruitment process to strengthen the healthcare workforce and improve service delivery in Government hospitals.

Union Govt urges CJP to end sit-in, help restore peace

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Centre on Monday requested the CJP protesters to end their sit-in and assist the administration in restoring normalcy. In a statement, Union Minister JP Nadda said discussions with the protesters took place after they proposed talks with the government earlier in the day.

A delegation of Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) met on Monday as protesters demanded accountability from the Government over the NEET-UG paper leak case. According to CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka, the meeting with Nadda happened where a demand for the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET-UG paper leak was raised.

Nadda said the meeting took place in a cordial atmosphere. “An initial verbal discussion was held in detail with their delegation, and they submitted a written petition to me around 4 PM,” said the Health Minister. Sources in Government said Nadda assured the two-member CJP delegation that the Government leadership will hold internal discussions on their demands and get back to them, after thousands of protesters tried to march to Parliament but were prevented by police.

CJP blamed the Union education minister as “directly responsible for multiple paper leaks, including NEET 2026, and other exam fiascos, most recently being CBSE 12th portal chaos and CUET exam delay.” The group’s



spokesperson Saurav Das in a social media post said that he and another spokesperson, Ashutosh Ranka, met Nadda at his house for 10 minutes and gave a letter of demands.

“While we submit a written letter with our demands, he has assured us that he will meanwhile speak internally. We are in that process...” Das said. “The minister assured us he will discuss this at the appropriate level. However, no commitments have been made so far. The peaceful protesters will not rest until the demand is met.”

He also shared a copy of the letter on social media. “There has been no systemic corrections or action taken by Pradhan, indicating his gross incompetency as the education minister,” the CJP said in the letter.

The CJP has been spearheading protests over alleged examination irregularities since June.

FROM PAGE - 1

General of Police, Tripura.”

Anurag Dhankar was from Baghpat in Uttar Pradesh and had over 30 years of experience in policing, intelligence, and investigations. He joined the IPS in 1994 and served in Tripura for almost 16 years, holding important roles like Inspector General of Police (Law and Order) and Director General (Intelligence). His knowledge of the state’s security and law-and-order issues earned him respect from colleagues and subordinates.

While on central deputation, Dhankar made important contributions at the national level. He worked in several roles with the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), eventually becoming Additional Director. He was especially known for leading the investigation into the Punjab National Bank fraud case involving Nirav Modi, one of India’s biggest financial crime cases. He also served with the United Nations Mission in Kosovo from 2003 to 2004.

SBI takes over Ram temple donation count

The first shift runs from 8 am to 2 pm, and the second from 2 pm to 8 pm. By rotating new teams every six hours, the trust hopes to reduce fatigue-related mistakes and limit the risk of wrongdoing. The trust has also appointed Shobhnath Mishra as the new head of cash counting.

The State Government formed a SIT on June 13 to investigate the matter. This led to an FIR being registered on June 25. Eight people, including former counting staff, were arrested in connection with the case. Authorities recovered cash, gold, silver, foreign currency, and a donation box labelled “Ramrajya Kosh.” One of the accused had over Rs 20 lakh. Subhash Srivastava, who previously oversaw cash counting, was also arrested and jailed.

The SC is overseeing the investigation, led by Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant and other senior officers. The SIT was expected to submit an interim report while the court reviews related petitions. The trust says it is working closely with UP Police and the SIT.

PM Modi opens Monsoon Session with dig at Rahul

The PM added, “Be it the monsoon or the Monsoon Session — if both are proactive, they prove to be highly productive. And when both are productive, it leads to the welfare of the nation and the well-being of all living beings. That is why we pray that the monsoon remains both proactive and productive, and that the monsoon session proves productive as well.”

PM Modi stressed that meaningful discussions should take place in the House and collective resolutions made to move the country forward.

Forty days of anger explodes on streets

The Cockroach Janata Party’s (CJP) Chalo Sansad march was met with batons charges near the Parliament Street, tear gas shells near the Shastri Bhawan and the Raisina Road, and mass detentions across central Delhi. Internet services were suspended in parts of the Capital. Several entry gates to the Parliament were shut.

Protesters attempting to reach Jantar Mantar from Mandi House Metro Station were assaulted by the police. By 4 pm, repeated tear gas shelling pushed protesters past a breaking point, and the demonstration turned violent. Stone-pelting began, and police vehicles were smashed near Rajiv Chowk. By evening, Jantar Mantar was completely empty, with protesters regrouped and gathered around Connaught Place and Rajiv Chowk. The CJP launched its sit-in at Jantar Mantar on June 6, over 40 days ago.

The demand throughout has been the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in NEET-UG 2026. The Government did not engage until Monday, the day of the march, when CJP spokesperson Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka were called in to meet Union Minister JP Nadda. Das posted from outside the meeting, “Our demands are clear. The youth have gathered in huge numbers.” After the meeting, he said Nadda had assured him he would speak internally, but that no commitments had been made.

The father of Riya Thapa, the NEET student who died by suicide, was present at Jantar Mantar and persuaded CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, who had himself been on hunger strike, to end his fast and lead the march. Dipke, addressing supporters earlier in the day, said, “This Government is not satisfied with taking the lives of 20 NEET students. They are now baying for the blood of others.”

The CJP posted as the internet was cut in parts of the city: “You can shut down the internet, but how will you close the eyes and ears of the protesters who will see and report?” Delhi Police Additional CP Rajeev Ranjan appealed for calm: “Delhi Police appeals to all protesters to maintain peace, exercise restraint, and cooperate with the police.”

Youth take their fight to Parliament, face police...

The incident resulted in injuries to over 118 police officers and approximately 60 protesters. Additionally, around 20 vehicles were damaged, and approximately 70 protesters were detained. The Delhi Police have also registered a case following Monday’s protest.

The protest at Jantar Mantar had been growing for weeks and had become one of the largest gatherings against what many see as problems in the education system. The CJP has held a sit-

in protest there since early June 2026.

The core demands include the immediate resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. The main demands are for Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign, for those responsible for repeated exam paper leaks to be held accountable, for reforms to stop such problems, and for compensation to families of students who died by suicide due to exam stress (with reports mentioning over a dozen cases).

Delhi Police said they acted to keep order and stop unauthorised marches into restricted areas. They denied using too much force or causing many injuries, and called some reports misinformation. Protesters said that force was used against women and younger participants.

Activist Sonam Wangchuk joined the protest with an indefinite hunger strike and was hospitalised on July 18 because of health issues. In a handwritten note from the hospital on Monday, Wangchuk said he would end his fast only if the Government took responsibility for the education system’s failures or if Members of Parliament from different parties promised to raise the issues in Parliament. Administrators are converging at the historic site to press their demands.

A delegation from the CJP met Union Minister JP Nadda after initial discussions began around noon. The meeting, described as cordial, took place in the afternoon. The delegation submitted a memorandum outlining their demands, including the Education Minister’s resignation, support for affected students and families, and related accountability measures. Nadda assured the group that their concerns would be conveyed to senior leadership for consideration. He also appealed to the protesters to end the sit-in and cooperate with efforts to restore normalcy in the area.

Opposition leaders sharply criticised the police response. Some said that using batons against students and youth protesters was an attack on democratic rights and the voices of young people. Several people were detained during the clashes, with estimates of 10-15 or more initially taken into custody. By Monday evening, the main protest was still underway at Jantar Mantar, though security forces had begun clearing some areas.

Tripura DGP Anurag Dhankar found dead

A post-mortem has been ordered to find the exact cause of death, and police and forensic teams are investigating the circumstances.

“Tripura Director General of Police Anurag Dhankar was found hanging in the washroom of his official chamber at the police headquarters on Monday,” according to Chief Minister Manik Saha. The CM said he visited the police headquarters with other top officials, including the chief secretary and the home secretary, after hearing the news. Saha wrote on Facebook, “I am deeply shocked and saddened by the tragic demise of Anurag, IPS, Director

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A 19-year-old Class 11 student was allegedly stabbed to death following a quarrel with a group of youngsters in Delhi’s Kalkaji on Sunday afternoon, police said.

The incident took place near a park in B Block of DDA Flats in Kalkaji. Police received a PCR call about a quarrel involving school students at 2.23 pm and rushed to the spot, where they found the victim lying with stab injuries. A CATS ambulance reached the scene, administered cardiopulmonary resuscitation (CPR), and then shifted the injured youth to the AIIMS Trauma Centre. However, doctors declared him dead on arrival.

The deceased was identified as Saiyed Husain (19), a resident of JJ Camp in Okhla Phase-II. Police said Husain was a Class 11 student at an MCD school in Kalkaji. Preliminary investigation suggests that Husain was stabbed during a quarrel involving two to three persons. “The victim sus-



tained stab injuries during an altercation. The accused have been identified and efforts are underway to trace and apprehend them at the earliest,” a senior police officer said. Police said multiple teams have been formed to arrest the suspects.

A case has been registered and investigators are examining CCTV footage from the area and questioning witnesses to reconstruct the sequence of events leading to the fatal attack. The motive behind the killing is yet to be established. The body has been sent for post-mortem examination, and further investigation is underway, he added.

changing demands.

This latest World Cup is therefore more than another trophy. It is evidence that Spain have evolved from a golden generation into a footballing institution. Teams are difficult to build. Rebuilding one may be even harder. Spain have now done both.

It completes one of international football’s most remarkable journeys: from decades of frustration to one of the greatest teams of the 21st century, through decline and reinvention, and back to the summit once again.

History will remember the medals and the silverware. But Spain’s greatest accomplishment may be something less tangible: the ability to repeatedly unite players from different footballing backgrounds around a shared identity.

The author is a sports management consultant with over a decade of experience in sports promotion and development

Opposition brings Parliament to a standstill

“Thousands of students have reached Jantar Mantar (where the protest is on), and they were lathi-charged,” he said. “The Government is trying to beat them down and suppress the issue,” Kharge said, as Opposition members shouted “shame, shame”.

Amid the uproar, the Chairman adjourned the House till noon. Opposition members continued raising slogans in favour of protesting students and the subsequent police action against them. They were also raising slogans against donation theft at Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, Uttar Pradesh.

Earlier, at 2 pm, Pal said there was adequate quorum to conduct business, but some Opposition MPs alleged they were being prevented from entering the House. Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said the House could not function if the disruptions continued. Previously, as soon as the House met at 11 am, opposition members started raising slogans, forcing Speaker Om Birla to adjourn the proceedings till 12 noon as the Question Hour was being taken up. Birla objected to two members raising slogans when obituary references were read out on the demise of six former MPs, saying it was not a good precedent.

When the House met again at 12 noon, noisy protests continued and the House was adjourned till 12:30 pm. Before the proceedings were adjourned, Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal introduced a bill to replace an ordinance which increased the number of Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38, including the Chief Justice of India. Similar disruption was witnessed at 12:30 pm when repeated pleas by the Chair to take up Zero Hour failed to get a positive response from opposition members. Dilip Saikia, who was in the Chair, adjourned the proceedings till 1 pm. When the House met at 1 PM, the protests by the opposition continued.

DCGI approves India’s first dengue vaccine–QDENG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has approved its first dengue vaccine, with the Drug Controller General of India (DCGI) granting market authorisation to the vaccine QDENG, developed by Takeda Biopharmaceuticals India.

The vaccine is approved for people aged 4 to 60 years and can be given regardless of whether a person has previously been infected with dengue.

Unlike the older dengue vaccine, Dengvaxia, QDENG does not require people to undergo blood testing to determine whether they have previously had dengue, a significant advantage for large-scale public health programmes.

“Since its launch in 2022, QDENG has been approved

in 43 countries, with more than 32 million doses distributed globally. This approval marks an important step forward in strengthening dengue prevention in India,” said Mahender Nayak, Head of Intercontinental Markets, Takeda.

The latest seven-year data for QDENG show continued protection against dengue infection and hospitalisation across all four serotypes, an important milestone for communities and health systems, he added.

The vaccine has already been approved in more than 40 countries, including the European Union, the United Kingdom, Brazil, Indonesia and Argentina. India now joins that list at a time when dengue is emerging as one of the country’s biggest seasonal public health threats.

The approval in India is



based on results from Takeda’s global clinical development programme, involving 19 Phase 1, 2 and 3 clinical trials with over 28,000 participants in both endemic and non-endemic regions, the company said.

It is also supported by data

from a Phase III clinical trial (DEN-302) conducted in Indian participants, which evaluated the safety and immunogenicity of the vaccine in individuals aged 4-60 years, it added.

The vaccine is administered subcutaneously, 0.5 ml as a

two-dose regimen, with doses given three months apart.

India carries a substantial dengue burden, and all four dengue virus serotypes have been documented as co-circulating in several regions, said Goh Choo Beng, Medical Affairs Head, Southeast Asia & India Cluster, Takeda.

“QDENG is designed to protect against all four serotypes, regardless of prior exposure. Its approval represents an important step in strengthening India’s comprehensive approach to dengue prevention, alongside vector control, surveillance, community awareness and other public health measures,” Beng added.

The company added that the World Health Organisation (WHO) recommends QDENG for use in dengue-endemic regions and supports its inclusion in public

immunisation programmes in high-transmission areas without requiring pre-vaccination screening.

QDENG has also received WHO prequalification, confirming that it meets international standards for quality, safety and effectiveness. This also makes the vaccine eligible for procurement by global agencies such as UNICEF and the Pan American Health Organisation (PAHO).

Dengue, a mosquito-borne viral disease, poses a significant global public health threat, with prevalence in over 125 countries. India accounts for nearly one-third of the global dengue burden, the company said.

Millions of Indians remain at risk each year due to widespread endemicity, rapid urbanisation and climate-related factors that drive mosquito proliferation, it added.

10 more die in Jammu rain havoc; death toll reaches 22

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

A day after devastating flash floods and landslides claimed 12 lives and left several others missing across Jammu division, 10 more civilians lost their lives on Monday, taking the death toll in the rain-battered region to 22.

According to official sources, seven people were buried alive when their house was struck by a massive landslide in the Domail Dhok area of Loran in Poonch district. The incident was reported after midnight, following flash floods that triggered massive mudslides.

Three persons were killed and six others injured after falling boulders struck a passenger bus and a house in two separate incidents in the hilly Doda district.

According to Deputy Commissioner Poonch, Ashok Kumar Sharma, seven people have lost their lives in the incident in Loran Dumilan village. He said all seven bodies have been retrieved. Among the seven killed, four were women.

Mohd Rafiq lost his wife, Zaida Begum, and two minor kids along with four other relatives.

In a separate incident, a rock rolled down a hillock near Raggi Nallah along the Jammu-Kishtwar national highway around 9.30 am amid torrential rains, hitting a passenger bus, the officials said.

They said a rescue operation was launched immediately, and seven injured persons were shifted to a nearby hospital, where one of them, identified as Manish Kumar, was declared brought dead.

In addition, the body of an unidentified person was recovered from the



damaged vehicle, the officials said, adding efforts are underway to establish the identity of the deceased.

The officials said the highway remained blocked as a couple of private vehicles were also hit by boulders in the area. However, the occupants of the vehicles escaped unhurt.

In another incident, a woman identified as Shiv Devi was killed after being hit by a shooting stone at her house in the Kashtigarh area of the district, the officials said.

Meanwhile, heavy rain on Monday severely hampered rescue operations in both Poonch and Rajouri districts.

The fresh spell of rain began around 3 am in the twin border districts and continued unabated, making rescue and search operations difficult in the affected areas.

Police, Army, SDRF and Civil Defence personnel and local volunteers continued rescue efforts despite the adverse weather, the officials said.

Moderate to heavy rainfall was reported from Jammu and several other districts, though there were no immediate reports of any loss of life or damage to property.

Earlier, a BJP delegation led by the Leader of the Opposition in the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly, Sunil Sharma, visited the flood-affected areas of Poonch and Rajouri districts to assess the damage caused by flash floods and landslides triggered by torrential rain.

West Bengal CM Suwendu releases 1993 firing report ahead of TMC rally

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

In a damaging development that could hurt the very purpose of observing the Trinamool Congress’ Martyrs’ Day by the Mamata Banerjee faction of the Trinamool Congress, Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Monday disclosed the long-pending report of the Justice Sushanta Chattopadhyay Commission.

The report incidentally comes just on the eve of the TMC’s observance of the 33rd Martyrs’ Day rally on July 21 and threatens to challenge Mamata Banerjee’s moral right to politically exploit the day, experts said.

According to the report presented before the Assembly, the police firing on Youth Congress demon-



strators on July 21 1993, killing 13 persons, was legally unwarranted.

The report said that the firing was carried out on the instructions of the then Home Secretary Manish Gupta. Instead of taking action against Gupta after becoming the Chief Minister, Mamata Banerjee not only sent him to Parliament but also made him a Cabinet Minister in his Government, post 2011.

The report had thus far

been kept under the carpet by the previous TMC Government notwithstanding its annual observance of the TMC Martyrs’ Day rally, when the kin of the deceased were honoured from the dais.

Chief Minister Adhikari also released the names of the 44 witnesses who were summoned by the Commission. Mamata Banerjee, who had always claimed to be a witness to the firing, however, was not summoned by the Commission.

Referring to the reports, the Chief Minister said: “Many people extracted benefits from the July 21 movement, some rose in power, some acquired status to go abroad, but the people of Bengal still do not know as to what really happened that day.”

Rahul slams baton charge on CJP protests, calls PM anti-youth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday dubbed Prime Minister Narendra Modi as the “most anti-youth” PM in the country’s history as he accused the Government of not just failing the youth but also pouncing on them.

Gandhi’s remarks came after security forces resorted to a baton-charge near Parliament Street after thousands of Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) supporters, protesting against the paper leaks, allegedly tried to breach barricades while marching towards Parliament on the first day of the Monsoon session.

As CJP supporters, including students, marched towards Parliament, the police tried to stop them and used tear gas and lathi-charged them.



Rahul Gandhi with Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi on Monday

PTI

“Prime Minister Modi is the ‘most anti-youth Prime Minister in India’s history - He’s so ‘anti-youth’ that he can’t even take the resignation of a failed Education Minister, Dharmendra Pradhan.

“152 paper leaks. 7.5 crore students victimised. And not a single guilty person punished. Who got the punishment? The hardworking youth,” he said in a post in Hindi on X.

Gandhi said when children raise legitimate questions about education, they are met with batons and detention in response.

“The criminals who leaked the papers roam free - and the students raising valid issues are dragged around, beaten.

“This Government is not just failing the youth - it is pouncing on them,” the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said.

Jitendra Singh calls for revisiting pension rules to minimise litigation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State for Personnel, Public Grievances & Pensions, Dr Jitendra Singh, on Monday called for a comprehensive review of pension regulations to ensure that evolving social realities are adequately reflected in Government policies, stating that many pension disputes arise because existing rules have failed to keep pace with changing societal needs.

He emphasised that the ultimate objective of pension administration should be to prevent litigation through timely policy reforms rather than resolving disputes after they reach the courts.

Addressing the 2nd National Workshop on Pension Litigation, organised by the Department of Pension & Pensioners’ Welfare, the Minister said the Government is committed to creating a zero-litigation pension ecosystem through simplified rules, improved grievance redressal, stronger coordination among Ministries and proactive identification of recurring issues before they develop into legal disputes.

During the event, Dr Jitendra Singh



launched the Compendium of Case Laws on Pension Litigation, a Flyer on Pension Litigation, and the Special Campaign 3.0 of the Department of Pension & Pensioners’ Welfare, aimed at strengthening litigation management, improving service delivery and promoting citizen-centric pension administration.

Singh observed that pension administration must continuously evolve alongside changing social realities. Referring to recent reforms, he highlighted the Government’s decision to extend pension benefits to separated daughters by simplifying eligibility conditions, thereby

eliminating the need for lengthy legal proceedings in many deserving cases. He said such reforms demonstrate the Government’s commitment to making pension policies more humane, inclusive and responsive to contemporary societal requirements.

The Minister also referred to reforms in family pension provisions, noting that outdated regulations inherited from earlier administrative frameworks often created hardship for beneficiaries. He said several such provisions have been revisited over the past few years to ensure that pensioners and their families are not compelled

to seek judicial intervention merely to receive legitimate benefits.

Earlier, welcoming the participants, Dhruvajyoti Sengupta, Joint Secretary, Department of Pension & Pensioners’ Welfare, said the Department’s vision is centred on improving the ease of life of pensioners through policy reforms, digital governance and effective litigation management. He informed that litigation cases on the Department’s Litigation Information Management System (LIMS) have declined by nearly 20 per cent over the past year, reflecting improved coordination among Ministries, legal counsels and departments.

The workshop was attended by Nivedita Shukla Verma, Secretary, Department of Pension & Pensioners’ Welfare; Sukriti Likhii, Secretary, Department of Ex-Servicemen Welfare; Dr Rajiv Mani, Secretary, Department of Legal Affairs; and R Venkataramani, I.d. Attorney General for India. The programme featured two technical sessions on pension litigation before tribunals and courts, litigation management, standardisation of case laws, and policy interventions aimed at minimising avoidable pension-related disputes.

CPI(M) condemns police action on students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Monday strongly condemned the police action against students and youth protesting at Jantar Mantar during a march to Parliament, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and the disbanding of the National Testing Agency (NTA).

Security forces resorted to a lathi-charge and used tear gas to disperse hundreds of demonstrators who had gathered following a call by student and youth outfits over alleged paper leaks and irregularities in the NEET examinations. Several protesters sustained injuries in the clash, which also witnessed police action near the CPI(M) headquarters at Gole Market.

In a press statement, the CPI(M) Polit Bureau alleged



CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby

that the police carried out “ferocious attacks” on peaceful demonstrators at the behest of the Union Home Ministry. The party accused the Centre of adopting a dictatorial approach and refusing to engage in dialogue despite a month-long nationwide protest.

“The paranoid Government, instead of being accountable for the growing mess in education and the pathetic situation of unemployment, has refused to have a dialogue with the protesters,” the statement

read, warning the Union Government that repressive measures would fail to suppress the growing anger among the country’s youth.

The party reiterated its demands for the immediate resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan, the dissolution of the NTA, and the unconditional release of all detained student activists.

Expressing solidarity with the protesting students, CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby lashed out at the Union Government for suppressing democratic protests.

“The brutal police action on students peacefully exercising their democratic rights at Jantar Mantar is unacceptable. Instead of fixing accountability for the NEET mess and addressing the grievances of millions of aspirants, the Modi Government is using police force to brutally crush student voices. Dharmendra Pradhan must step down immediately on moral grounds,” MA Baby said.

ASI received 121 nods for archaeological projects in five years, says Union Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

There were 121 instances when permission was granted for the ASI to carry out archaeological projects in the country in the last five years, the Government informed Parliament on Monday.

Union Culture Minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat shared the data in a written response to a query in Lok Sabha.

He was also asked for details of any court orders regarding the continuance or closure of any archaeological projects during the last five years and the action taken thereof.

“There is no court order regarding the continuation or closure of any archaeological projects during the last five years,” Shekhawat said.

There are 3,686 centrally protected monuments and sites under the care and main-



tenance of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) across the country.

The Union minister was also asked about the sites where the ASI is doing excavation across the country along with expenditure incurred thereon and the timeline set for completion of works; and the details of historical findings discovered from the archaeological projects carried out during the last five years and scientific validations thereof.

In tabulated data, he shared that 121 instances of permission were issued for carrying out archaeological

projects by the ASI in the last five years.

In 2021-22, as many as 24 instances of permission were issued, while in 2022-23, the figure stood at 31; and for 2024 and 2025, the numbers stood at 22 and 25, respectively.

“During excavation, structural remains, burials, pottery and antiquities such as coins, beads, ornaments, agricultural tools, bone objects, etc. have been unearthed and, as per set practice, samples are sent to various institutions for scientific validations whenever required,” the minister added.

Datia bypoll: BJP deploys top leaders for booth duty

GIRISH SHARMA
■ Bhopal

With the high-stakes Datia Assembly by-election entering a crucial phase, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has launched an aggressive organisational campaign by deploying senior leaders, former ministers, former MLAs and experienced office-bearers to oversee booth-level operations, signalling the party’s focus on micro-management to retain the prestigious seat.

While Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, State BJP president Hemant Khandelwal, State BJP in-charge Mahendra Singh, ministers and senior leaders are spearheading the campaign, the party has simultaneously activated its grassroots network by assigning veteran leaders to individual Shakti Kendras, the BJP’s key organisational units responsible for booth management and voter mobilisation.

Under the strategy, each Shakti Kendra has been



assigned a Prabhari (in-charge) and a Sangathak (organiser), who will jointly supervise four to six polling booths. Their responsibilities include coordinating booth-level workers, strengthening voter outreach, monitoring election preparedness and ensuring effective management on polling day.

According to the list issued by the Datia district BJP unit, senior leaders have been assigned responsibilities across Datia Urban, Datia Rural, Badoni, Bhandar, Indergarh and Seondha mandals. Several former ministers, former legislators and experienced organisational functionaries have been entrusted with the task of

ensuring seamless coordination between the party organisation and grassroots workers.

The move comes as the BJP intensifies its campaign for the July 30 bypoll, widely seen as a prestige battle for the ruling party. The election assumes added significance after the party fielded Ashutosh Tiwari, replacing senior leader and former Home Minister Narottam Mishra, whose supporters had initially expressed resentment over the ticket decision before the leadership moved swiftly to restore unity within the organisation.

Party leaders believe that booth management remains the backbone of the BJP’s electoral success. By assigning experienced leaders to every Shakti Kendra, the organisation aims to strengthen voter contact, improve coordination among workers and maximise voter turnout on polling day.

Speaking about the party’s election strategy, BJP State president Hemant

Khandelwal said the BJP’s greatest strength lies in its disciplined cadre and robust organisational structure. He said every worker has an important role in the election, adding that the party remains in “election mode” throughout the year through continuous coordination with booth, mandal, district and State-level workers. Khandelwal also expressed confidence that the BJP would register a decisive victory in the Datia bypoll, saying the organisation was united and fully committed to ensuring the success of the party’s candidate.

A Shakti Kendra is regarded as one of the BJP’s most important organisational units, serving as the link between the party leadership and booth-level workers. With two senior functionaries supervising each cluster of booths, the BJP hopes to ensure meticulous planning, efficient voter mobilisation and effective election-day management as it seeks to retain the Datia Assembly seat.



States Focus



LANDSLIDES HIT GUWAHATI; LOCALS ASKED TO STAY ALERT

Several landslides were reported in Guwahati on Monday, with the authorities issuing an alert for more rainfall in the city over the next 24 hours, aggravating the situation. Kamrup Metropolitan District Commissioner Swapneel Paul said landslides were reported from at least five locations, though no casualties have been reported so far. The affected areas include Kamakhya main road beyond Prashanti Lodge, Kamakhya Colony near Ganesh Mandir, Paschim Kamakhya village near the water tanker, Pandu Temple Ghat and Madhavdevnagar in Maligaon, he said. People have been advised to avoid unnecessary travel in hilly areas of the district, particularly around Maligaon and Pandu, he said.

(PNS)



DOVAL TO RECEIVE LOKMANYA TILAK AWARD ON AUGUST 1

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval has been selected for the prestigious Lokmanya Tilak Award for his significant contribution to the field of national security, the Tilak Smarak Trust announced on Monday. Union Home Minister Amit Shah will present the award to Doval at a function in Pune on August 1. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy CMs Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Pawar are likely to attend the event, the trust's president, Dr Rohit Tilak, said at a press conference. The award ceremony will be held at the Maharashtra Mandal ground in the Gultekdi area of Pune. Doval, 81, has handled crucial assignments in sensitive regions, including Mizoram, Sikkim, Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir. He also served in diplomatic roles at Indian missions in Islamabad and London. He is the longest-serving National Security Advisor of India. Doval has served as India's special representative for the India-China boundary talks and is also credited with playing an important role in diplomatic efforts that helped resolve the Doklam standoff.

(PTI)

MP Govt tables UCC Bill in Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

The Madhya Pradesh Government on Monday introduced the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill in the Assembly, where noisy scenes were witnessed as the Opposition demanded a discussion on the alleged land purchases linked to Chief Minister Mohan Yadav. The State Government tabled the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill, 2026, on the opening day of the five-day monsoon session, even as Congress members demanded an urgent debate on the alleged scam in Ujjain. The House was adjourned for 30 minutes after Congress members trooped into the well. Speaker Narendra Singh



Madhya Pradesh Assembly speaker Narendra Singh Tomar being greeted by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav in Bhopal on Monday

Tomar said the House would take up discussion on the UCC Bill on Tuesday. A recent newspaper report had claimed that Yadav and his family members purchased huge land parcels after the latter became the chief minister — a charge

denied by the BJP as baseless. As soon as the Question Hour concluded, Leader of the Opposition Umang Singhar raised the issue of land purchases linked to the chief minister and family through an adjournment motion, inviting strong objec-

tions from BJP legislators and ministers. Assembly Affairs Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya opposed the demand, saying the matter could not be taken up through an adjournment motion. He contended that the adjournment motion is usually taken up on recent developments and not on old ones. Congress MLAs trooped into the well of the House shouting slogans, and Singhar maintained that the adjournment motion pertained to the alleged acquisition of land linked to the Simhashta area and the alleged purchase of land by the chief minister's family, insisting on a debate. As the Congress members refused to relent, the Speaker adjourned the proceedings for 30 minutes.

DMK legislator held for defamatory speech against TN CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tuticorin (Tamil Nadu)

Opposition DMK MLA, GV Markandeyan, was arrested on Monday for allegedly making defamatory remarks against Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, drawing sharp criticism from the party president MK Stalin, who denounced the police action.

Markandeyan, representing the Vilathikulam Assembly constituency, was picked up by a police team from his residence amidst protests by his supporters who raised slogans condemning the police action.

He was later arrested, a police official said, and added that his arrest followed a complaint from the ruling TVK functionary over his controversial speech threatening the chief minister.

The police registered an FIR against Markandeyan under three sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) — criminal intimidation, intentional insult with intent to provoke breaching public peace, and spreading false information, following a com-



Opposition DMK MLA, GV Markandeyan

plaint lodged by P Kasiram, the Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam functionary, the official said.

While addressing a public meeting in Kovilpatti in the district on July 18, Markandeyan had issued threats and made derogatory remarks against the chief minister, which were found in bad taste. Kasiram had said in his complaint to the police.

In the viral video of his arrest, the legislator could be heard saying that he could not be arrested without the permission of the Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker, since he was an MLA. The police had to convince the MLA to take him to the police station, even as his supporters staged a protest in front of his house.

Markandeyan is the second legislator from the DMK to be arrested from the Tuticorin district within weeks. Former State minister Anita R Radhakrishnan, representing the Tiruchendur Assembly constituency in the district, was arrested on July 3, allegedly for making a defamatory speech against Vijay.

Strongly condemning the arrest, Stalin accused the ruling TVK of political vendetta and said the former DMK ministers and party legislators were "continuously hunted" for pointing out the mistakes and misdeeds done by the current regime. "The court recently pulled up the Government for adding unrelated criminal sections even in defama-

tion cases," the former Chief Minister said on 'X' and claimed that the arrested MLA was denied a meeting with his lawyer and supporters.

"Those who went to deliver medicines to him (Markandeyan) were prevented, and even the basic legal and human rights of the arrested person have also been denied. Is what is happening in Tamil Nadu the rule of law or the rule of Satan?" Stalin asked.

He sought to know why the TVK Government, which is "reluctant to take action against a minister who powdered a tablet in the stadium, those involved in the gang rape of a woman, was arresting those making political remarks."

The DMK chief was apparently referring to the incident of a TVK functionary, who, before becoming a minister, had powdered a pill to be administered to his daughter who fell sick during a cricket match, and also the alleged sexual assault of a woman in Tuticorin under the pretext of providing her a job.

West Bengal Govt to make all communications in Bangla from September 1, says CM



SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Monday announced the mandatory use of Bangla as a language of communication in official transactions, in addition to his Government deciding to create a Special Investigating Agency along the lines of the National Investigating Agency to preempt future possible security threats.

The decisions come a day after the conclusion of Union Home Minister Amit Shah's three-day trip to the State during which he emphasised the promotion of India's rich cultural heritage on the sidelines of reviewing the State's internal and border security system.

All the official communications within the administration and with the public would be in Bangla. This would include the First Information Reports lodged by the police too, the Chief Minister said.

During his speech in the State Assembly, Adhikari said, "Bangla will be mandatorily used in all the official communications of the State Government... this will be implemented at all levels from September 1... the intervening period will be used for translating the documents," he said, adding the State in its communication with the central Government will use Hindi alongside Bengali for that purpose. Referring to a letter from

Shah to this end, the Chief Minister said how the Home Minister in his letter written in Bangla invoked Bharatiya Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee's dream for the preservation and promotion of Indian languages.

In his letter written in Bengali, Shah recalled how Mookerjee was an "ardent supporter of conservation, development and the extensive use of Indian languages." Shah, in his letter, advised the use of Bangla and Rajbhasha (State language) Hindi "instead of a foreign language, for in official communications with the Central Government," Adhikari said.

Referring to the file management, departmental communications and official notings, Shah in his letter said, "I believe that on the 125th birth anniversary of Syama Prasad Mookerjee, your Government will take effective steps for the extensive use and development of Indian languages"

The Home Minister on Sunday, while inaugurating India's first immersive language museum at the National Library, had extensively dwelt on the rejuvenation and reinvigoration of national heritage and culture, putting it back on the centre stage. "There is no bar in gathering information about foreign culture, languages, etc but there is an urgent need for the revival of Indian cultural heritage, which can only be possible through the learning of the mother tongue," he said.

Karnataka Congress questions ONGC CSR funds to RSS-linked organisations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Congress president BK Hariprasad on Monday questioned the alleged flow of ONGC's CSR funds to organisations linked to the RSS and demanded greater transparency and accountability in the use of public resources.

Referring to a media report, Hariprasad alleged that state-owned ONGC had channelled ₹668 crore in CSR funds to 20 RSS-linked organisations over the past decade and said the issue warranted public scrutiny. "It's reported that Rs 668 crore of ONGC's CSR funds reportedly flowed to 20 RSS-linked organisations over the last decade," Hariprasad said



Karnataka Congress president BK Hariprasad

in a post on 'X'.

He further alleged that the reported funding pattern should be viewed alongside "the recurring allegations of public resources — from temple offerings and disaster relief funds to Covid relief,

public land, and Kalyana Karnataka development funds — being channelled into the Sangh ecosystem." Hariprasad questioned the RSS's claim that it does not receive government funds, saying, "Yet the @RSSorg

claims it doesn't take Govt funds. If public institutions & taxpayer-backed resources are funding your affiliates, how can RSS claim to be independent of govt money?"

He said the debate had gone beyond the question of registration and added, "The issue is no longer registration alone; it is transparency, accountability, and the right of citizens to know how public money is being spent."

Demanding answers from the RSS, the Karnataka Congress chief said, "RSS should not evade further questions on its funding and how correct it is morally for an unregistered organisation to receive such funds." There was no immediate response from ONGC.

Gujarat: Murder accused attacks cops, killed in encounter

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Anand

A man accused of kidnapping and murdering a minor girl was killed in an encounter in Gujarat's Anand district after he allegedly attacked police personnel with a concealed knife while trying to escape from custody, an official said on Monday.

Two policemen sustained injuries in the attack on Sunday night. The accused, whom the police shot in self-defence, died during treatment, Inspector General of Ahmedabad Range Raghavendra Vatsa said.

"A person accused of kidnapping and killing a minor girl has been killed in an encounter as he tried to escape after attacking police with a concealed knife on Sunday night. Two policemen received injuries in the knife attack," Vatsa told reporters. Police identified the deceased as Suresh Parmar, in his late 20s, who was accused of kidnapping and murdering a four-and-a-half-year-old girl from Vasad in the district.



According to Anand police, the girl was sleeping with her parents, who are migrant labourers, on a platform at the Vasad railway station and was abducted at around 9.15 pm on Saturday. Later, the body was found on the railway tracks early on Sunday.

The railway station's CCTV footage showed the accused taking the child away. Multiple teams of the railway

police, Anand district police, Local Crime Branch (LCB), Special Operations Group and Vasad police launched a search operation.

Parmar, a resident of Borsad town in Anand, was arrested late Sunday evening by Borsad rural police and handed over to the LCB for further investigation, the police said.

While the LCB personnel were bringing Parmar to Anand town on Sunday night, he asked the escorting team to stop the vehicle, claiming he needed to vomit. After the vehicle halted, he allegedly attacked two policemen with a hidden knife in an attempt to flee, causing injuries to both of them, they said.

A sub-inspector repeatedly warned the accused to surrender, but he continued the attack, forcing the police to open fire in self-defence, the police said.

Parmar sustained a bullet injury and was taken to a hospital in Karamsad, where he succumbed to his injuries in the early hours of Monday, they added.

Out of total CSR only 8.4% spent on environment in FY-2023-24: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

While the amount deployed in environmental corporate social responsibility (CSR) has steadily increased in recent years, only 8.4 per cent of the total CSR was spent on it in the financial year 2023-24, according to a report.

It also stated that among India's 50 most climate-vulnerable districts, 30 of them received only 1 per cent (Rs 106 crore) of total environmental CSR spending over the past three years.

The report, 'A Decade of Green Spending: What ₹17,000 Crores of Environmental CSR Reveals About Corporate India', was released by Sattva Consulting, a global impact consulting firm, on Monday.

It also revealed that sectors with some of the largest environmental footprints, including energy, mining, and oil, gas, coal and petroleum, show relatively low participa-



tion in environmental CSR. "Sectors with high pollution intensity, including oil, gas, coal and petroleum, mining, and energy, allocate only 5-7 per cent of their CSR budgets to environmental initiatives... By contrast, consumer-facing sectors such as FMCG and automotive allocate over 10-15 per cent of CSR to environmental themes," said the report.

The analysis highlighted that high-value environmental CSR projects (₹50 lakh and above) in FY 2023-24, water management (15 per cent), renewable energy (12

per cent), and biodiversity (11 per cent) together account for 38 per cent of all high-value project funding.

However, air quality, despite its acute public health relevance, received just Rs 14 crore, around 5 per cent of the high-value project pool.

In a statement, Srikrishna Sridhar Murthy, co-Founder and CEO of Sattva Consulting, said, "India's climate ambitions will require every form of capital to work more strategically. As climate risks increasingly affect business operations, supply chains and communities."

6 killed as truck collides with car in Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Wardha (Maharashtra)

Six persons were killed when a truck crashed into a car on the Mumbai-Nagpur Samruddhi Expressway in Maharashtra's Wardha district early on Monday, police said.

The two vehicles caught fire after the accident that occurred at around 3 am near Virul village. Traffic movement on the busy expressway was disrupted.

A container truck carrying ethanol overturned near interchange IC-80 on the expressway. While another lane remained operational, a stationary car on the road was struck from behind by a truck, and both vehicles caught fire, a senior police official said.

Four car passengers and two occupants of the truck, including its driver, died in the accident, he said.

Teams from the Highway Safety Patrol, Wardha Police, fire brigade, and the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation rushed to the spot for rescue and traffic restoration operations.

Since the overturned container was carrying highly flammable ethanol, it was necessary to empty it first before its safe removal. The operation was underway with utmost caution to ensure public safety, the official said.

Traffic on the Mumbai-Nagpur carriage-way was being diverted to the opposite lane, causing heavy congestion along the affected stretch. Police also advised motorists trav-



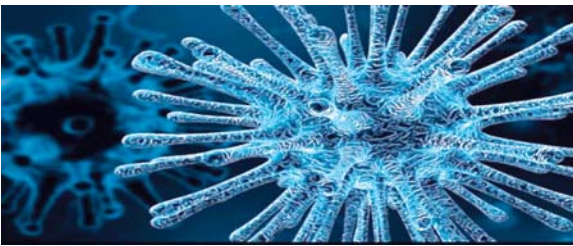
elling from Nagpur to Mumbai to avoid using the Samruddhi Expressway up to Wardha for the next few hours. They asked people to use the Nagpur-Amravati highway and rejoin the expressway through the Amravati gate interchange.

Efforts were underway to facilitate the safe clearance of the accident site.

Notably, the Samruddhi Expressway recorded 185 accidents in 2025, a 35 per cent increase from the 2024 figure of 137, as per the highway police data.

The 701-km six-lane access-controlled highway, which connects Vidarbha's largest city to the country's financial Capital, has been opened to traffic in phases since December 2022. An Intelligent Traffic Management System is currently under implementation to improve monitoring and enhance road safety, officials earlier said.

Gujarat reports 63 suspected Chandipura cases, 12 test positive



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Gujarat has recorded 63 suspected cases of Chandipura virus, of which 12 have tested positive, according to a review of the situation by the State health authorities.

A review meeting chaired by Health Minister Praful Pansheriya examined the geographical spread of reported cases, possible sources of transmission, laboratory testing and measures undertaken by the administration.

Of the 12 positive cases,

nine are from Gujarat, and three are from Rajasthan. The positive cases in Gujarat have been reported from Panchmahal and Kheda, which have recorded two cases each, while Sabarkantha, Mehsana, Bharuch, Bhavnagar and the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation area have reported one case each.

The Health Minister directed officials to maintain intensive surveillance in areas reporting cases and conduct detailed investigations into patients' travel and medical histories to identify possible sources of infection.

Army deployed as flood worsens in Upper Assam; rail services hit

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Incessant rains worsened the flood situation in Upper Assam on Monday, requiring the deployment of Army personnel to assist state agencies in relief and rescue operations, while rail traffic was hit in the region with several trains rerouted, suspended or short-terminated. According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), five people have died so far in this year's floods. More than 57,100 people in Charaideo, Dhemaji, Dibrugarh, Jorhat, Sivasagar, Tinsukia and Udalguri districts have been affected by the deluge, it said.

Several tea estates in the state are under floodwaters, with the Assam unit of the Tea Association of India saying that rivers from Nagaland have swelled suddenly and were flowing above the danger level. The breach of the embankment on the Dorika River aggravated the situation, inundating extensive stretches of the tea estates in the Nazira region, it said. Northeast Frontier Railway said that due to heavy rainfall, the swollen Dikhow river flooded Simaluguri town in Sivasagar district in Tinsukia Division. "Floodwaters have entered the station yard and the railway colony. Railway tracks in the area have also been inundated. For passenger safety, train movement in the Simaluguri-Namtiali and Simaluguri-Selenghat sections has been suspended until



further notice," it said. Long-distance trains from Dibrugarh and Tinsukia have been diverted through the Rangiya-Rangapara route on the north bank of the Brahmaputra while several local trains have either been cancelled or short-terminated.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said four of his cabinet colleagues are on the ground and monitoring the rescue and relief operations. He has asked all MPs and MLAs of the affected districts to be at the flood-hit

areas to oversee the rapidly changing situation. "In Sivasagar, 510 people have been rescued by SDRF and the Fire and Emergency Services. Rescue efforts continue with additional boats and Army helicopters deployed to reach inaccessible areas," the Chief Minister's office posted on social media. In Charaideo, the National Disaster Response Force, its state counterpart and Army teams have been deployed in the worst-hit areas, while relief measures are under-

way to ensure the safety and well-being of affected residents, it added. On Sunday night, Sarma said the state government requested the Army and Air Force to be on standby to assist the local administration in evacuating flood victims from several districts affected by the deluge.

"Flood-fighting work is underway in Jorhat, Charaideo and Sivasagar. Sand-filled bags are being dumped along the Dikhow embankment, geobags are being used to reinforce the Disang riverbank and flood-fighting work is underway at the Jhanji embankment in Norakonwar Bailung Gaon," the CMO said. It said the Jhanji river was showing a receding trend with the water level falling by 0.04 metres since morning.

Sarma said unprecedented rainfall over the last few days has aggravated the flood situation in Sivasagar and neighbouring districts.

"We remain committed to providing all sorts of assistance to the affected... Rescue efforts are underway and are being monitored by our ministerial team," he added.

As rains continue, the administration is reinforcing its efforts to shift people to safer places and provide them with all necessary support, the Chief Minister said.

Sarma said on Sunday that he directed his ministerial colleagues Ajanta Neog, Bimal Borah, Keshab Mahanta and Susanta Borgohain to immediately reach the affected areas to supervise relief efforts.

IndiGo to place order for over 1,000 aircraft engines with CFM International

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The country's largest airline IndiGo on Monday announced it will place an order with CFM International for more than 1,000 engines to power its 510 A320 neo family planes. IndiGo and CFM International, an equal joint venture between GE Aerospace and Safran Aircraft Engines, have inked a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) for the order at the Farnborough International Airshow in the UK.

The order for more than 1,000 LEAP-1A engines to power 510 Airbus A320 neo family aircraft will also be the "largest single order ever placed for LEAP engines and a record for CFM International," a release said on Monday.

Financial details were not disclosed. A320 neo family planes include A320 neos, A321 neos and A321 XLRs. All are narrow-body aircraft.

CFM International would also provide extensive support to the airline in establishing its engine MRO (Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul) facility in Bengaluru. Besides, it will provide support to the IndiGo fleet through long-term material services agreement, including supply of spare parts.

Currently, IndiGo has an operational fleet of over 400 planes and over 900 Airbus aircraft are on order.

"CFM has been a trusted partner in our growth journey since 2016, supporting a fleet that now



exceeds 375 A320/321Family aircraft. The LEAP engine's industry-leading proven reliability makes it the ideal choice to support our scale, operational resilience and sustainability ambitions," IndiGo CEO Designate Willie Walsh said.

IndiGo has been a customer of CFM International for 10 years.

In 2016, the airline operated a sub-fleet of Airbus A320 ceo family aircraft powered by CFM56-5B engines and in 2019, the airline ordered LEAP-1A engines for their newest fleet of Airbus A320/321 neo family aircraft.

India is the third largest market for CFM International, with 5 Indian carriers operating more than 400 LEAP-powered aircraft and 2,000 engines on order.

GE Aerospace Chairman and CEO H Lawrence Culp, Jr said that with a strong installed base, manufacturing in Pune, a broad local supplier network, and

advanced engineering in Bengaluru, we remain committed to supporting IndiGo's growth and expanding our presence in India.

"As one of the world's fastest-growing aviation markets, India is of strategic importance to Safran. Through our continued investments in the country, particularly in LEAP engine production and MRO capabilities, we are strengthening our long-term commitment to supporting IndiGo's remarkable growth and to contributing to the development of Indian aerospace industry," Safran CEO Olivier Andries said.

Meanwhile, many planes are grounded due to issues with Pratt & Whitney (P&W) engines.

Earlier in the day, Honeywell Aerospace announced that IndiGo has selected its avionics and power systems for 810 new Airbus A320 neo family aircraft that are to be delivered in the coming years.

DGCA ISSUES 1,331 PILOT LICENCES TILL JUNE: GOVT

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 1,331 commercial pilot licences have been issued by aviation watchdog DGCA this year till June 30, and out of them, 41 per cent of the cadets were trained overseas, according to the Government.

The data was submitted to the Rajya Sabha on Monday as part of a written reply by Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol.

This year, till June 30, commercial pilot licences were issued to 791 cadets from Indian Flying Training Organisations (FTOs) and 540 cadets from foreign FTOs.

The licences were issued to 1,652 cadets and 1,347 cadets in 2025 and 2024, respectively. As per the data, a total of 1,622 persons were issued the licences in 2023, higher than the 1,165 people who received the licences in 2022.

Currently, there are 41 DGCA-approved FTOs with 63 bases across the country with more than 400 aircraft.

DGCA norms stipulate Aircraft: Instructor: Student ratio as 1:1:10, which corresponds to training capacity of around 3,500 students at these FTOs at any given point of time, Mohol said.

The minister said the Government has taken several steps to strengthen pilot training infrastructure in the country, including simplifying and streamlining the approval and oversight process for FTOs, and revising training regulations.

Polluted river stretches drop to 296, says Govt



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The number of polluted river stretches in the country has declined from 351 in 2018 to 296 in 2025, based on biochemical oxygen demand (BOD), an indicator of organic pollution, the Government informed the Rajya Sabha on Monday.

In a written reply to the House, Minister of State for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary said the number of polluted river stretches had come down to 311 in 2022, before further declining to 296 in 2025, according to the latest report of the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

He said rivers are polluted mainly due to the discharge of untreated or partially treated sewage from cities and towns, industrial effluents, inadequate dilution, dumping of solid waste on riverbanks, agricultural runoff, geogenic effects and other non-point sources of pollution.

The minister said the CPCB, in association with State Pollution Control Boards (SPCBs) and Pollution Control Committees (PCCs),

monitors river water quality through a network of 2,265 monitoring stations under the National Water Quality Monitoring Programme. Choudhary said the government has incurred ₹11,332 crore under the Namami Gange programme and ₹1,888 crore under the National River Conservation Plan for river pollution abatement, in addition to schemes being implemented by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs.

He said that while no standards have been prescribed specifically for heavy metals in rivers, they assess such parameters as pH, biochemical oxygen demand (BOD), dissolved oxygen (DO), and faecal coliform (FC) to gauge river pollution.

The minister said the CPCB has one Central Water Laboratory in Delhi and eight regional laboratories for analysis of water quality parameters, while state pollution control boards have their own labs recognised either by the National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories (NABL) or under the Environment (Protection) Act.

Sikkim CM presents ₹19,215 crore Budget for 2026-27

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

Sikkim Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang on Monday tabled in the Assembly a Budget of ₹19,215 crore for the financial year 2026-27, with the focus on developing infrastructure and social welfare measures.

Tamang, who holds charge of the finance department, said his government has significantly expanded public investment through enhanced State revenues, prudent fiscal management and mobilisation of additional resources from the Centre and externally aided projects. Presenting the budget on

the first day of the four-day session of the Assembly, he proposed a gross expenditure of ₹19,215 crore for the financial year 2026-27, with a net expenditure of ₹18,455 crore after accounting for recoveries.

"The Budget would be financed through Sikkim's own revenues, transfers from the Government of India and prudent borrowings, with allocations prioritising good governance, infrastructure development and social welfare," Tamang said.

The revenue expenditure has been estimated at ₹11,733 crore, while ₹5,896 crore has been marked for capital expenditure excluding loans



and advances, the CM said.

He said that the State Government has earmarked ₹2,460 crore for its share under the Centrally Sponsored Schemes to accelerate development across

sectors, it is informed.

Exuding confidence about the financial health of the Himalayan state, Tamang said Sikkim has emerged as one of the most progressive states in the country, record-

ing an average real Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) growth of over 12.6 per cent during the past eight years.

He said that the state has the highest per capita GSDP in the country and has witnessed significant improvements in human development, poverty reduction and household income.

Reaffirming the Government's vision of Viksit Sikkim @2047, he said the state aims to sustain an average annual GSDP growth of over 13 per cent through sound governance, strategic investments and citizen-centric development. The CM further said

that Sikkim's GSDP at current prices is projected at ₹62,973 crore in 2026-27.

Among major announcements regarding the priorities of the State Government in the current fiscal, he said that the state government proposed to provide statewide Human Papilloma Virus (HPV) screening to around 1.5 lakh women aged 30 to 65 years as part of its efforts to eliminate cervical cancer.

The CM also announced the operationalisation of Sikkim's first Renal Transplant Programme at STNM Hospital enabling patients to undergo kidney transplantation within the State.

Haryana revises ex-Agniveer reservation norms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Haryana Government has revised the implementation of its existing reservation policy for ex-Agniveers in direct recruitment by specifying the category-wise distribution of the 20 per cent reservation available for select Government posts.

Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi has issued revised instructions, partially modifying the government's earlier order dated August 20, 2025, relating to reservation for ex-Agniveers in direct recruitment.

Under the revised provisions, the overall 20 per cent reservation remains unchanged, but the



Government has now notified its category-wise distribution for direct recruitment to the posts of Forest Guard in the Environment, Forests and Wildlife Department, Prison Warden in the Prisons Department and Mining Guard in the Department of Mines and Geology.

"As per the revised breakup, 2 per cent of the reservation has been earmarked for Deprived Scheduled Castes (DSC), 2 per cent for Other Scheduled Castes (OSC), 3 per cent for Backward Class-A (BC-A), 2 per cent for Backward Class-B (BC-B), 2 per cent for the

Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) and the remaining 9 per cent for the Unreserved category, taking the total reservation for Ex-Agniveers to 20 per cent," an official statement said here on Monday.

The revised provisions also prescribe separate roster points for each category to ensure uniform implementation of the reservation policy during recruitment. The Human Resources Department has directed all concerned authorities to bring the revised instructions to the notice of all stakeholders and ensure compliance in letter and spirit.

The fresh instructions have been circulated to all

Administrative Secretaries, Heads of Departments, Managing Directors of Boards and Corporations, Divisional Commissioners, Deputy Commissioners, the Registrar General of the Punjab and Haryana High Court and Registrars of all state universities for compliance, it said.

Earlier, the Haryana Government had decided to provide the benefit of horizontal reservation in direct recruitment to resident ex-Agniveers of the State. In April 2026, the Haryana cabinet had decided to enhance the 10 per cent horizontal reservation for ex-Agniveers to 20 per cent in the services or posts under the State Government.

Special court sentences 44 Somali pirates to life imprisonment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

A special court in Mumbai on Monday sentenced 44 Somali nationals to life imprisonment in two different cases on charges of piracy and other offences.

The court also appreciated the bravery of Indian Navy in discharging legal and international duty in letter and spirit by taking all cost and risk. While imposing the maximum punishment of life imprisonment, Special Judge S B Dige noted that the offences committed by the accused persons were serious in nature. All the 44 accused, comprising 35 in one case and nine in the other, had pleaded guilty before the court and had urged for leniency.

The court said it was aware of the poor condition of the accused persons and the fact that they have voluntarily pleaded guilty. "But on the other hand, the act of piracy on high sea by hijacking a vessel and keeping crew members hostage for ransom by attempting to kill them and to keep them as human shield and not obeying the lawful directions of Indian Navy are very serious things which cannot be taken casually," the court said.

The accused have been convicted under Indian Penal Code, Arms Act, Passport Act, Foreigners Act, Maritime Anti-Piracy Act and the Explosive Substances Act.

Strategic initiatives reviewed to strengthen Goa's position as year-round tourism destination

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Goa Tourism on Monday reviewed a series of strategic initiatives as part of efforts to strengthen the state's position as a year-round tourism destination.

These included a proposed partnership with global travel major TUI Group, plans for World Tourism Day 2026 celebrations and the promotion of sports tourism, officials said.

The initiatives were discussed at the 29th meeting of the Empowered Committee on Marketing and Public Relations under the Goa Tourism Board, chaired by State Tourism Minister Rohan Khaunte, they added.

According to the Department of Tourism, the committee deliberated on measures to expand destination marketing, strengthen global partnerships, promote sports tourism, enhance digital engagement and deepen stakeholder collaboration.

The committee also reviewed preparations for World Tourism Day 2026, which Goa plans to celebrate on a large scale under the UN Tourism theme 'Digital Agenda and Artificial Intelligence to Redesign Tourism', it added.

The Department of Tourism, in collaboration with Travel and Tourism Association of Goa (TTAG), is planning month-long activities involving stakeholders,



industry partners and local communities, with a focus on

innovation, digital transformation, sustainability and responsible tourism.

The committee also discussed proposals related to hosting marquee sporting

events such as IRONMAN 70.3 Goa and Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT), which are expected to attract new visitor segments and further diversify the state's tourism offerings, officials said.

Speaking after the meeting, Khaunte said, "Goa's tourism strategy is centred on long-term, sustainable growth through strategic planning and partnerships. Our focus remains on creating a resilient, future-ready tourism ecosystem that keeps Goa competitive across global markets while showcasing the state's diverse tourism offerings throughout the year."

The committee also discussed a proposed partnership with TUI Group to

enhance Goa's visibility in key European markets during the 2026-27 tourist season through destination marketing campaigns, trade engagement and sustainable tourism promotion.

Tourism Director Kedar Naik said the discussions reflected the department's focus on innovation, international partnerships, experiential tourism and community participation to build a sustainable tourism ecosystem.

The meeting reaffirmed Goa Tourism's commitment to collaborative planning and sustainable tourism development aimed at enhancing visitor experiences and strengthening the state's global competitiveness, the department said.



Editor's
TAKE

FIFA World Cup: Spain rules the world again

Football once again demonstrated its unrivalled global appeal, uniting nations, cultures and generations in a way few events can

Cricket may be the religion of the Indian subcontinent, but football is the religion of the world. Sunday's proof came from MetLife Stadium in New Jersey, where Spain outlasted Argentina 1-0 in extra time to become world champions for the second time. Substitute Ferran Torres settled a stubborn final in the 106th minute, likely closing the book on Lionel Messi's extraordinary World Cup career and confirming what football fans have suspected for two years: this Spanish side is the finest on the planet.

La Roja's route was no procession. World Cup debutants Cape Verde defended heroically to hold them to a goalless draw in the opener, but Spain settled quickly, topping their group unbeaten before knockout-round scalps of Cristiano Ronaldo's Portugal and, in the semi-final, Kylian Mbappé's France. Along the way, goalkeeper Unai Simón set a World Cup record with six clean sheets, and Spain conceded only once in seven matches - the tightest defence any champion has fielded.

Nineteen-year-old Lamine Yamal, still managing an injury picked up before the tournament, became only the third-youngest player ever to feature in a World Cup final. Individually, the honours were shared. Rodri, Spain's captain, imperious midfield anchor and the 2024 Ballon d'Or winner, won the Golden Ball ahead of Messi and Mbappé - recognition that control, not chaos, wins tournaments. Mbappé, despite France's fourth-place finish, claimed the Golden Boot with ten goals, his second in as many World Cups and the first time anyone has repeated the feat. Messi, who dragged a young Argentina side to the final at 39, collects a Silver Ball as consolation in what he has said will be his last World Cup.

For Spain, this is more than another trophy. Paired with their Euro 2024 title and a 38-match unbeaten run, it confirms that a golden generation - Yamal, already a Ballon d'Or runner-up at 19, alongside Pau Cubarsí and Pedri - has inherited the tiki-taka blueprint and fused it with a defence built to match. Luis de la Fuente's side has delivered back-to-back major titles, echoing the legendary 2008-2012 dynasty that won three in a row, and with most of this core still in their early twenties, a run at Euro 2028 already looms.

Spanish academies remain world football's most reliable factory of champions. And yet in India, this triumph will register as a footnote beside the next cricket series. India's men's team is ranked 138th in the world, this year's ISL season was disrupted by a boardroom dispute serious enough to reach the Supreme Court, and no Indian city has ever hosted a senior FIFA World Cup fixture. Cricket's commercial machine - the IPL, blanket television coverage, a fan base nurtured since colonial times - leaves little oxygen for football to grow beyond pockets in Kolkata, Kerala, Goa and the Northeast. Sunil Chhetri's era inspired millions, but India still awaits a true successor and, more urgently, the grassroots pitches and school-level coaching that turn passion into a footballing nation. Until administration catches up with appetite, India will keep watching the world's game from the boundary line.

The entrepreneurs building a self-reliant India

India has long been home to millions of skilled micro-processors making distinctive local products. What many of them lacked was affordable finance, modern technology, quality certification and a way into organised markets



CHIRAG PASWAN

When the COVID-19 pandemic disrupted lives and livelihoods in 2020, Prime Minister Narendra Modi recognised that recovery had to reach beyond large industry. It had to reach the smallest producers and enterprises, especially those working in India's villages and small towns.

The Pradhan Mantri Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises Scheme was launched that year under the Aatmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan with this purpose. It began with a part of the food economy that had long remained outside formal finance and institutional support: the micro-processor already producing, selling and employing a few people, but without the capital or guidance needed to grow. The scheme reflected a conviction the Prime Minister has consistently held, that India's growth must begin at its base, among people willing to build enterprises of their own.

The credit-linked component of PMFME has now crossed two lakh sanctions. The milestone matters because of the people behind it, entrepreneurs who have entered the formal credit system and secured a real chance to build. It is an achievement worth celebrating, and a moment to honour those who made it possible.

The first of them was Jamnalal Patidar, whose application was the very first sanctioned under PMFME. A tenth-pass entrepreneur with no background in food processing, he began a coriander-processing unit with an investment of ₹10 lakh. With the scheme behind him, he gained access to finance, machinery and guidance, and his idea grew into a working enterprise that today employs more than five people.

His story makes a simple point. Enterprise is not the privilege of the well-born or the well-schooled. It turns on whether a person with an idea can find the finance, technology and support needed to act on it. By enabling ordinary Indians to build enterprises and employ others, PMFME is carrying forward the Prime Minister's vision of turning job-seekers into job-creators.

India has long been home to millions of skilled micro-processors making distinctive local products. What many of them lacked was affordable finance, modern technology, quality certification and a way into organised markets. The scheme was built to close those gaps together, through credit-linked assistance, capacity building, common infrastructure,



THE PRADHAN MANTRI FORMALISATION OF MICRO FOOD PROCESSING ENTERPRISES SCHEME WAS LAUNCHED THAT YEAR UNDER THE AATMANIRBHAR BHARAT ABHIYAN WITH THIS PURPOSE. IT BEGAN WITH A PART OF THE FOOD ECONOMY THAT HAD LONG REMAINED OUTSIDE FORMAL FINANCE AND INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT

The writer is the Union Minister for Food Processing Industries

branding and market linkage, and to bring informal enterprises into the formal economy where they have a real chance to grow.

Women have been among the principal drivers of this change. Nearly 44 per cent of the two lakh credit-linked sanctions have gone to enterprises led by women, while more than four lakh Self-Help Group members have received seed capital to strengthen and upgrade their businesses. The scheme as a whole has drawn more than ₹20,300 crore in investment and enabled close to six lakh livelihood opportunities. More than 75,000 units have entered the formal economy through Udyam registration and compliance under FSSAI and GST. For many women, this has meant turning skills practised within the household or community into recognised enterprises with access to finance, technology and wider markets. Helping many more make that transition must remain central to the phase ahead.

Behind each of these numbers is a wider gain. A working enterprise buys a farmer's produce, cuts the loss that once followed every harvest, and keeps more value close to where it is made. A local crop becomes a branded product. A household skill becomes steady employment. In time, a district comes to be known for what it makes. This is Vocal for Local in practice, one enterprise at a time.

The sanction that carried PMFME to two lakh went to Inderjeet Singh of Ranchi, who is building a bakery and dreams that his cakes and pastries will one day be known across Jharkhand.

Like Patidar before him, he begins with a small venture and a large ambition, and he begins with the scheme behind him. He is one of thousands of first-generation entrepreneurs PMFME is now carrying from a first

sanction towards a thriving enterprise. If Patidar shows how far this journey can travel, Singh shows that it is still gathering pace.

That is the shape of the road ahead. Opening formal credit to micro-processors was the first task, and the harder, more rewarding one is to help each sanction become a disbursed loan, and each loan a business that trades and endures. A sanction opens the door; our work is to help every entrepreneur walk through it and build something that lasts.

This must define the next phase of PMFME. We will get credit to promising enterprises faster, help them adopt better technology and packaging, widen their access to markets, and prepare many more of them to reach buyers at home and abroad. And we will stand with our entrepreneurs after the sanction, not only before it, with the steady support that turns a first loan into a lasting livelihood.

Taken together, these two lakh sanctions are far more than an administrative milestone. Each enterprise that takes root strengthens the economy around it. It buys from nearby farms, creates income closer to home, and gives more women and young Indians the confidence to build businesses of their own.

When we look at Patidar's coriander unit, the lesson is simple. The first sanction under PMFME went to a man with no established factory and no specialised degree. What he had was an idea and the will to work; what the scheme gave him was access. Two lakh sanctions later, that opportunity has reached entrepreneurs across the country. Our task now is to help more of them build businesses that survive, employ others and create value where they begin.

What India can learn from Japan's teaching culture



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

Every education system in the world generates instructors. Very few produce teaching cultures. This delicate, almost invisible distinction is what makes Japan worth studying, not for its technology or test scores, but for the silent philosophy that drives what happens inside its classrooms and, more importantly, its staffrooms.

Consider Jugyo Kenkyu, or Lesson Study, a collaborative practice that has existed in Japanese education for more than a century. A group of teachers jointly plans a lesson. One teacher conducts it while the others observe how students respond, where they struggle and what helps them understand. Afterwards, the group discusses and refines the lesson. The purpose is not to rate the teacher but to examine the learning. In too many Indian schools, classroom observation still arrives wearing the uniform of appraisal. Lesson Study offers a different possibility:

observation as professional cooperation rather than judgement.

The second useful idea is Kaizen, i.e. continuous improvement through small and consistent changes. Indian education remains fascinated by the grand gesture: the new policy, revised assessment pattern or digital platform that promises to transform learning. But transformation is rarely an event. It is an accumulation. A teacher who regularly asks, "What did not work today, and what can I change tomorrow?" may improve more meaningfully than one who attends several ceremonial workshops. Kaizen dignifies the small. Then there is Ho-Ren-So, an abbreviation of h?koku (report), renraku (inform) and s?dan (consult). It is a Japanese workplace principle based on communicating early, sharing relevant information and seeking guidance before problems become crises. Anyone who has worked in an Indian school understands how much energy is lost when communication fails. Ho-Ren-So is not unnecessary bureaucracy. It is courtesy converted into a system. Schools that communicate early and laterally become calmer institutions, and calm institutions teach better.

Another idea, Omoiyari, means understanding others' feelings and responding with consideration. In schools, it helps teachers notice a quiet child, an overwhelmed colleague or a parent's hidden concerns.

A fifth lesson comes from Tokkatsu, or Special Activities, through which Japanese schools integrate cooperation, responsibility and participation into daily life. Students may help clean classrooms, serve lunch and take responsibility

ity for shared spaces. Character is not outsourced to a weekly moral education period. It is built into the ordinary rhythm of the school day. Japan's insight is simple: character is caught more often than it is taught. If schools want responsible students, the conduct of adults becomes part of the curriculum. A final lesson comes from Japan's well-being culture: Shinrin-yoku, or forest bathing, the practice of restoring oneself through mindful time in nature. The idea may sound indulgent until one considers teacher exhaustion: correction loads, data entry, duty rosters, administrative paperwork and the emotional labour of managing dozens of children. A depleted teacher cannot remain endlessly patient, creative and compassionate. Rest is not softness; rather, it is sustainability. Japan's education system is neither free from pressure nor should it be romanticised. The purpose is not to copy another country uncritically, but to identify ideas that can be adapted intelligently. Strong teaching cultures assume that excellence is collaborative, incremental, empathetic and sustainable. As India implements the National Education Policy (NEP), we must ask whether we are genuinely building professional capacity or merely conducting training. Training fills a hall for a day. Culture fills a career.

A teacher's influence begins somewhere very ordinary: in a staffroom where teachers trust one another, in a lesson improved collectively, in a problem communicated before it grows and in the quiet act of noticing a child.

The writer is an educator and a councillor

SPAIN ENDS SIXTEEN-YEAR WAIT WITH HISTORIC WORLD CUP WIN

On Sunday, Spain secured their second FIFA World Cup title after a 16-year wait. Substitute Ferran Torres emerged as the unlikely hero, scoring the decisive goal in the 106th minute of extra time to seal a hard-fought 1-0 victory over defending champions Argentina. Spain's triumph was about far more than lifting the trophy; it was a testament to resilience, tactical discipline and unwavering belief throughout the tournament.

For 19-year-old talent Lamine Yamal, who became the fourth teenager in history to win a FIFA World Cup, the victory marked another extraordinary milestone in his rise that has already captivated the footballing world.

Spain produced a masterclass in collective football, dominating

possession, controlling the midfield and effectively neutralising Lionel Messi's influence without resorting to man-marking. By remaining faithful to their trademark passing game, La Roja demonstrated that a cohesive, technically superior system can outmatch even the most gifted individuals.

The final was also a tribute to Argentina's courage and determination. The reigning champions fought relentlessly until the final whistle, pushing an outstanding Spanish side to its limits. Although La Albiceleste fell short in their bid to retain the title, their resilience and remarkable campaign earned admiration across the football world.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

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Time for public audit to put land at the centre of governance

The question that public audit must increasingly ask is simple: Does the government know what land it owns, where it is located, how it is being used, whether it is encroached upon, and whether it is creating public value? This question is not technical. It goes to the heart of public accountability



VIVEK KUMAR SINGH

Public audit in India has traditionally followed the money. It examines whether expenditure was authorised, whether procedure was followed, whether revenue was collected, and whether public funds were properly used. But one of the most valuable public assets often remains outside the centre of

audit attention — land. Land is the silent base of public governance, infrastructure, welfare delivery, urban expansion, environmental protection and economic development. Yet governments often know less about their land than about far less valuable assets. While elaborate systems exist for accounting for buildings, vehicles, machinery and financial assets, information on land is frequently fragmented, outdated or incomplete.

The question that public audit must increasingly ask is simple: Does the government know what land it owns, where it is located, how it is being used, whether it is encroached upon, and whether it is creating public value? This question is not technical. It goes to the heart of public accountability.

Weak land governance affects public finances, project delivery, citizen services, environmental protection and public trust. Acquisition delays push up costs. Weak records generate uncertainty. Encroachments erode public assets. Poorly managed land remains idle while public institutions search for space. Faulty compensation records can lead to overpayment, litigation or exclusion of rightful beneficiaries. Yet public discourse usually views land through narrow lenses like ownership disputes, acquisition controversies, mutation delays or revenue administration. These are important, but they often describe symptoms rather than causes. Land governance is not one department's routine function. It is a connected system of maps, records, transactions, updates and ground possession. When these links do not speak to one another, the state begins to carry multiple versions of the same parcel.

A registered sale may not update revenue records. A revenue correction may not reach municipal databases. A court order may not be reflected in administrative records. A map may say one thing, a register another, and actual possession something else. For an auditor, this is not merely a clerical inconsistency. It is a risk signal. The traditional auditor asked, "Was the transaction proper?" The modern auditor asks, "Did the system work?" The future auditor must ask, "Was public value created?" Land governance is perhaps the most suitable field for this transition. Take government land, for example. In theory, it is a valuable public asset. In practice, many departments do not even have complete and updated inventories of their land holdings. Information on location, area, present use, ownership status, encroachment, litigation and valuation is often scattered. A department may lose public land not because someone formally transferred it, but because nobody knew it was its own land in the first place.

This calls for an asset-management approach to land. Government must identify, inventorise, protect, utilise and monitor public land with the same seriousness with which it manages other valuable assets. In fact, land deserves greater attention because it is finite, difficult to replace, and often appreciates over time. The same logic applies to acquisition and compensation. Many project delays are attributed to contractors, funding gaps or execution weaknesses. But quite often, the real bottleneck lies earlier, in poor planning, faulty surveys, weak consultation, unclear ownership records, repeated alignment changes and compensation disputes. Compensation administration, too, is not merely a payment process. It involves the identification of rightful beneficiaries, accurate measurement, correct valuation and timely disbursement. Errors can lead to duplicate payments, exclusion, litigation and fiscal loss.

A useful audit lens is to move beyond the lazy shorthand of "land disputes". In public administration, many problems that reach the state as disputes are actually



LAND GOVERNANCE ALSO HAS A DIRECT BEARING ON CITIZEN TRUST. FOR MANY CITIZENS, THE STATE IS ENCOUNTERED NOT IN PARLIAMENT OR THE SECRETARIAT, BUT IN THE REGISTRATION OFFICE, REVENUE OFFICE, MUTATION COUNTER, SURVEY CAMP, COMPENSATION HEARING OR GRIEVANCE FORUM

The writer is an ex-IAS officer and is presently Chairman, RERA Bihar. He served as Principal Secretary, Department of Revenue and Land Reforms, Bihar

system failures wearing the mask of disputes. A boundary conflict may be the result of outdated spatial information. An ownership mismatch may arise from delayed record correction. A disputed compensation payment may reflect weak beneficiary identification. An encroachment may reveal not merely an enforcement failure, but the absence of a reliable public land inventory.

This distinction matters because audit is strongest when it diagnoses causes, not merely records symptoms. If every land problem is treated as a dispute, the response naturally moves towards adjudication, litigation and file-bound resolution. But if the problem is understood as a survey failure, record failure, registration failure, possession mismatch or asset-management failure, the remedy becomes more precise. The auditor's role is not to sit in judgement over title, but to ask whether the system that records, protects, updates and verifies land is working as it should.

Digitisation has opened new possibilities, but also new risks. Online records, digital mutation workflows, registration databases and citizen portals can improve transparency and service delivery. But technology cannot cure bad data. An inaccurate paper record does not become accurate merely because it is digitised. In fact, digitisation can amplify old errors by making them more widely accessible and more quickly replicated. validation, correction mechanisms, access controls, audit trails and interoperability. If digital systems remain isolated, governments may only replace paper silos with digital silos.

The next frontier is geospatial and technological audit. GIS, satellite imagery, drone surveys, spatial databases and AI can help auditors move beyond departmental records. They can verify encroachments, land use, infrastructure progress, environmental compliance and acquisition claims through independent spatial evidence. This does not reduce the importance of documents. It strengthens audit evidence. Land governance also has a direct bearing on citizen trust. For many citizens, the state is encountered not in Parliament or the Secretariat, but in the registration office, revenue office, mutation counter, survey camp, compensation hearing or grievance forum. When records are unreliable, mutations delayed, encroachments unchecked or compensation disputed, the credibility of governance suffers.

Therefore, land audit should not be confined to revenue audit. It cuts across performance audit, compliance audit, IT audit, environmental audit, infrastructure audit and asset-management audit. A mutation backlog is not merely a service-delivery issue. A weak land inventory is not merely a departmental lapse.

A flawed acquisition process is not merely a project delay. Each is part of a larger governance risk. India's public audit institutions have an opportunity to widen the frame. Land must be seen not only as a legal subject, revenue matter or administrative routine, but also as a strategic public asset. The test of good land governance is not merely whether files moved, records were digitised or transactions were registered. The real test is whether public assets were protected, fiscal risks reduced, citizens served, infrastructure delivered, environmental safeguards maintained and public value created.

In public finance, what is not counted is often not controlled. In land governance, what is not known is eventually lost. Public audit must, therefore, also begin to ask a basic question that governments have too often avoided: "Do we really know the land we govern?"

India's private space age has arrived



PRAVIN KAUSHAL

On the morning of July 18, 2026, a seven-storey rocket lifted off from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota, climbed for roughly fifteen minutes, and placed several payloads into orbit some 450 kilometres above the Earth. The rocket was Vikram 1. The company that built it, Skyroot Aerospace, is not a government arm, not a legacy defence contractor, and not even a decade old. With this single launch, India became only the third country in the world, after the United States and China, where a privately built company has independently designed, constructed, and flown its own rocket into orbit.

It is worth sitting with that fact before moving on to the human story around it, because the number that matters most here is not four payloads or 450 kilometres. It is six. Six years ago, in May 2020, the Government of India announced that the space sector, until then a strict government monopoly, would be opened to private participation. Six years later, an Indian startup has done something only two other nations have managed at the level of private industry. That is an extraordinarily short runway for a result of this magnitude, and it deserves to be the actual headline.

For most of independent India's history, space was constitutionally the exclusive domain of the state. The Indian Space Research Organisation designed the launch vehicles, built the satellites, and owned the launch pads; private firms, at best, supplied components and hoped for a contract. This was not unique to space. Telecom, coal, aviation, and banking all operated for decades on the same premise: that certain sectors were too strategic or too capital-intensive to entrust to private hands. The costs of that premise rarely show up immediately. They show up as absence: as a generation of engineers who dreamed of building rockets but had exactly one employer to dream about; as capital that might have funded ten competing approaches to a hard problem instead funding one; as innovation that thrives on rivalry never getting a field to compete in. Closed sectors do not just constrain companies. They constrain what an entire generation is permitted to imagine for itself.

The two engineers behind Skyroot understood this from the inside. Pawan Kumar Chandana and Naga Bharath Daka met as scientists at ISRO, one having worked on India's heaviest launch vehicle, the GSLV Mark III, the other bringing expertise in the avionics that let a rocket sense its own position and correct its path mid-flight. In June 2018, while it was still, in practical terms, unthinkable for a private company to build its own rocket in India, they left secure government careers to start one anyway, with ten people and \$1.5 million in seed funding. Eight years and more than \$160 million later, that bet has produced a rocket now in orbit.

It is tempting to tell this purely as a story of individual daring, and it is that. But it would be a mistake to read Vikram 1 as proof that the private sector succeeded where the government failed. The truth is closer to the opposite. Chandana and Daka's technical skill was built inside ISRO, on the back of decades of public investment in their training. More than seventy technologies developed within ISRO have since been formally transferred to private industry, letting companies like Skyroot build on government research rather than start from zero. What changed in 2020 was not the talent. It was the permission, and the establishment of IN-SPaCe as a single-window regulator, so a startup no longer needed to navigate ISRO's internal processes just to test a rocket engine. Government investment supplied the skill; policy reform supplied the outlet. Vikram 1 is what happens when those two things are finally allowed to meet. The rocket's name is itself a quiet argument for that reading. It honours Vikram Sarabhai, the physicist who founded ISRO in 1969 on the conviction that a poor country could not afford to stay out of space, not to compete with wealthier nations for prestige, but because space technology was how India could leapfrog straight to solving problems on the ground: connecting villages, tracking monsoons, mapping resources. Sarabhai built that vision inside government because, in his era, there was no other institution capable of building it. Chandana and Daka have now shown that the same vision can be built outside it too, not instead of the government's role, but as an extension of it. There is a strategic dimension worth naming plainly. India's space economy is currently valued at roughly \$8.4 billion, about two per cent of the global total, a modest share for a country that trains a disproportionate share of the world's engineers. The government's own projections put that figure at around \$44 billion by 2033 and \$100 billion by 2040. None of that growth was available while the sector legally belonged to a single government department. More than three hundred private space startups are now active in India, up from a handful five years ago, and the sector already supports close to a hundred thousand jobs. A country that can launch small satellites reliably and cheaply, precisely the market Vikram 1 was built for, is also a country that can become the launch partner of choice for the dozens of developing nations that want satellite access to agriculture data, disaster monitoring, and communications, but will never build a Sriharikota of their own. That is not only a commercial opportunity. It is a geopolitical one, and India is now positioned to claim it early.

None of this guarantees what comes next. Skyroot must still prove it can launch repeatedly, not just once; that it can compete on cost with established players; that international customers and insurers will trust a young company with expensive payloads. Those are real hurdles, and the company has been candid that they remain ahead of it. But the sequence that got India here is not really in dispute: the sector was closed, then it was opened, and within six years of opening, a company with no state backing put a rocket into orbit. That sequence is the real lesson of July 18, not that India has arrived in space, which it did in 1969, but that India has learned something about how to get out of its own way, and did not take nearly as long to learn it as history might have suggested.



The writer is a tech and social entrepreneur and Programme Director (Eastern India) at WHEELS Global Foundation, a Pan-IT alumni initiative working across 20+ states in India

India's obesity challenge among adults: A call for action



M SRINIVAS

NEHA BAKSHI

India's nutrition journey is undergoing a profound transition. While the country continues to make progress in reducing undernutrition and improving food security, a new challenge is rapidly emerging, which is obesity. The changing food environment, increased availability of calorie-dense foods and inadequate physical activity have contributed to the rising obesity burden.

The NFHS-6 report highlights the magnitude of this emerging challenge. The prevalence of overweight/obesity among adults aged 15-49 years has increased among women from 24 per cent to 30.7 per cent and among men from 22.9 per cent to 27.3 per cent since NFHS-5. These trends indicate the need for a critical rethinking of India's approach to nutrition, health and lifestyle in the coming decades.

As per the World Health Organization, overweight/obesity is the excessive deposition of fat in our body to an extent that it starts limiting our

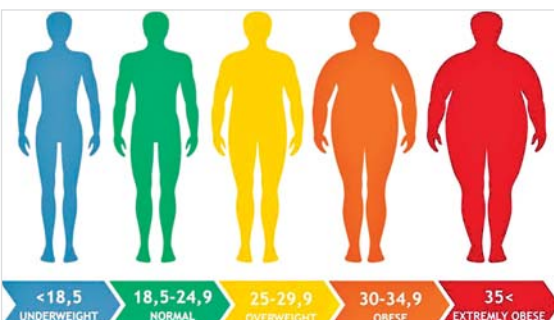
everyday activities and overall health. Body Mass Index (BMI) is used for assessing overweight/obesity. A person with a BMI >25 kg/m² is classified as overweight/obese. This increasing weight is not just a number; it puts individuals at serious risk of developing lifestyle-related diseases like diabetes, hypertension, cardiovascular diseases and others.

Rising trend of obesity: NFHS-5 to NFHS-6

India has seen this rise in overweight/obesity in previous surveys as well, but the pace at which the number has increased in the latest NFHS-6 data is concerning. According to NFHS-3 (2005-06), 12.6 per cent of women and 9.3 per cent of men were reported to be overweight/obese. Now, the figures in NFHS-6 (2023-24) stand at 30.7 per cent for women and 27.3 per cent for men. Thus, in two decades, the prevalence rate has approximately doubled among women and tripled among men. Even traditionally leaner states have shown rapid progress towards obesity; for example, Rajasthan went from 12.9 per cent (NFHS-5) to 20.3 per cent (NFHS-6).

A nationwide surge in overweight/obesity

The survey depicted that 32 and 28 states and UTs have shown an increasing trend in overweight/obesity among women and men, respectively, since NFHS-5. The highest burden of



obesity is borne by the southern parts of the country. Among women, prevalence was highest in Puducherry (51.3 per cent), Lakshadweep (50.1 per cent), Andhra Pradesh (47.9 per cent), Sikkim (47.5 per cent), Kerala (46.7 per cent) and Goa (45.1 per cent). For men, the rising burden was reported in the states/UTs of Chandigarh (48.5 per cent), Puducherry (45.9 per cent), Andaman and Nicobar Islands (46.1 per cent), Goa (43.6 per cent) and Andhra Pradesh (41.5 per cent). In contrast, the lowest prevalence among women was reported in Meghalaya (13.8 per cent), Jharkhand (16.9 per cent), Nagaland (17.2 per cent), Assam (19.6 per cent) and Bihar (19.8 per cent). Among men, Meghalaya (15.6 per cent), Chhattisgarh (16.1 per cent), Jharkhand (16.8 per cent), Madhya Pradesh (17.6 per cent) and Rajasthan (19.3 per cent) recorded the lowest prevalence.

The urban-rural picture

NFHS-6 shows that overweight/obesity, which

was once a concern limited to city dwellers, is now becoming a rising issue in rural areas across the country. The NFHS-6 data has shown a rise in overweight and obesity in urban and rural areas among women and men. It could be because of the increased penetration of High Fat, Salt and Sugar foods at cheaper prices in both urban and rural areas.

Efforts of the Govt in tackling obesity

Understanding the magnitude of the issue, both the Central Government and different state governments have initiated various programmes to promote a healthy lifestyle. The Eat Right India initiative, launched by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), promotes healthy, safe and sustainable food practices. The National Programme for Prevention and Control of Non-Communicable Diseases (NP-NCD) also focuses on mass screening, early diagnosis and behaviour change. The Fit India Movement and Khelo India initiative are nationwide movements to promote an active lifestyle among schoolchildren and youth, while the Ministry of Ayush promotes yoga and other traditional healthy practices.

Recognising obesity as an emerging public health challenge, the Prime Minister of India, Narendra Modi, addressed the nation on the auspicious occasion of Independence Day in 2025 from the Red Fort. He called for a movement towards a healthy life and for every family to take up the '10 per cent less oil' promise as a way of life to prevent obesity.

Way forward

The programmes and initiatives by the government show its commitment towards curbing obesity; the NFHS-6 data highlights the need to further strengthen existing efforts for prevention. There is an urgent need to improve the food environment by reducing the availability and aggressive marketing of junk foods, while promoting access to healthy foods and clear nutrition labelling. Physical activity should be promoted through schools, workplaces, community spaces and active urban and rural planning.

It is high time for us to understand the depth of the rising problem of obesity. There is a need to consciously incorporate a healthy way of living by adopting practices such as monitoring our weight status and waist circumference, eating a balanced diet, regularly engaging in daily physical activity, practising mindful eating, avoiding high-fat, salt and sugar foods, and consulting a medical professional if suffering from other comorbidities like diabetes, hypertension, etc. India's malnutrition challenge encompasses both undernutrition and overweight/obesity. Government intervention programmes have laid a good foundation; now, we need continued efforts in promoting a healthy food environment, an active lifestyle and nutrition literacy. As India progresses towards Viksit Bharat 2047, citizens adopting a healthy lifestyle will play a key role in the country's social and economic progress.

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Order Order

SC gives Parsvnath Developers one week to pay home buyer dues



The Supreme Court on Monday granted Parsvnath Developers one week as the final opportunity to comply with orders passed in favour of homebuyers in Gurugram by depositing the entire amount along with 12 per cent interest with the registry within one week.

Observing that failure to do so would result in imprisonment, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana made very strong remarks against the real estate firm and its directors. "The whole country has been duped by them. If you (real estate firm and its directors) do not comply with the orders within a week, they will be sent to jail. They are making a mockery of the system.

"The same thing that happened to the Unitech (directors) will happen to them (Parsvnath Developers). The entire system has been hijacked," the CJ said.

The case pertained to a petition filed by one Rita Tikku, a cancer survivor, and Lokaish Tikku, who invested their life savings in the 'Parsvnath Exotica' project in Sector 53, Gurugram. The bench noted that the Haryana Government has filed the status report as directed by it earlier.

"The Haryana Government states that a compliance affidavit has been filed. However, the same was filed last evening and not tagged with the paper books. Let it be done immediately," it said.

The bench said the respondent builder and its officials have entered an appearance.

"Let them explain non-adherence to orders by HRERA (Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority). Before the execution of non-bailable warrants, which is already issued, we grant the last opportunity to the builders to deposit the entire recoverable amount along with interest of 12 per cent per annum with the Supreme Court registry. (PTI)

SC to direct nationwide APAAR consent compliance

The Supreme Court on Monday said it will direct the CBSE to implement a direction of the Orissa High Court to amend the model consent form for the generation of Automated Permanent Academic Account Registry IDs to provide parents with the option to refuse consent or opt out of the scheme.



Under the Automated Permanent Academic Account Registry (APAAR) scheme, launched by the Ministry of Education under the New Education Policy, 2020, a unique, lifelong 12-digit student ID is generated. It acts as a digital passport for all educational records, securely storing marksheets, degrees and co-curricular achievements in one place.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing a plea filed by the parents of four students challenging the validity of the APAAR ID scheme for students on the ground that it compelled them to obtain Aadhaar IDs.

The top court said that since the Centre has not challenged the high court's December 2025 judgement, it would direct the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to implement the ruling nationwide.

"We will direct the CBSE to implement this judgement on a pan-India basis, as the High Court order has been accepted. We are directing the CBSE to examine the issues as well," the bench said.

It said a formal order would be uploaded later. (PTI)

SC asks Government to frame former-judges' benefits policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the Centre to set up a panel for a uniform national policy regarding post-retirement benefits like services of drivers, security and stay in Government accommodations while travelling for former high court judges.

Observing that there was a wide disparity in benefits extended by different states, a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, to set up within two weeks the panel, which in turn, gives its report on the issue within three months.



The bench was hearing a contempt petition filed by Justice VS Dave, President of the Association of Retired Judges of the Supreme Court and High Courts, raising the issue of security and other facilities for retired judges.

During the hearing, the CJ questioned the adequacy of the financial assistance currently provided by some states for engaging security



SC rejects Govt's plea on CPV outsourcing tenders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed the Centre's plea challenging a Delhi High Court verdict that quashed the tender process for outsourcing Consular, Passport and Visa (CPV) services at Indian missions in Abu Dhabi, Kuwait, Singapore and Canberra.

The top court, however, allowed the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) and Engineers India Limited (EIL) to make temporary arrangements to ensure uninterrupted delivery of services while a fresh tender process is completed. "The SLP (special leave petition of the Centre) is dismissed.

"However, having heard learned counsel for the parties and taking note of the submissions made before us, we are of the view that no impediment should be caused to the day-to-day functioning of the concerned establishments pending the completion of the fresh tender process," the bench said. To ensure continuity of services and compliance with the directions issued by the high court, the top court modified the impugned order.

"It shall be open to EIL and the MEA to make suitable interim arrangements for continuation of the subject services. Such interim arrangements may include engagement of the successful L-1 bidders whose performance has been found satisfactory, or any other agency, in such a manner as EIL and the MEA



may consider appropriate."

It, however, made clear that such an arrangement shall be purely temporary and not create any special equities in favour of any party, and remain subject to the outcome of the fresh Request for Proposal (RFP) process.

"The MEA shall ensure compliance with the earlier directions as well as the directions contained in this order and shall complete the fresh tender/RFP exercise as expeditiously as possible, preferably within a period of three months," it ordered.

The bench clarified that this interim arrangement is made without prejudice to the rights and contentions of all parties and no party shall claim any equity on the basis of this arrangement.

The bench was hearing the Centre's petition against the July 17 Delhi High Court verdict directing the Government to issue a fresh RFP after finding serious deficiencies in the technical evaluation process. Appearing for the Centre, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta argued that the high court's decision had adversely impact-

ed the functioning of Indian missions abroad, forcing embassy personnel to divert from their regular duties to manage visa-related services.

"Our embassy staff has been diverted. The tender holder always engaged in some litigation. But this time we decided to let them participate in the open tender process," Mehta said. The bench orally said that the Government had "invited" the high court's adverse findings by failing to record reasons for its evaluation. The solicitor general justified the actions and said that bidders could not be mechanically assigned comparative scores across different missions.

"We are dealing with four different embassies. Abhishek Singhvi's client may get two marks in Abu Dhabi but five in Singapore. If the same marking is given, then something is fishy," Mehta said.

Earlier on July 17, the CJI-led bench agreed to hear on July 20 the Centre's plea against the High Court verdict setting aside the tender awarded to private firms for outsourcing CPV services at some

Indian missions.

The High Court had directed the Centre to issue a fresh RFP, inviting fresh bids.

The Solicitor General said that fresh tenders were awarded following the procedure, but no new entity can start functioning straightaway, and as a result, such services have almost become dysfunctional.

In its verdict, the high court said that while taking the decision, the Centre relied on undisclosed comparative standards, made unexplained deductions under objective evaluation criteria, and adopted inconsistent marking. The high court said that these deficiencies struck at the very heart of transparency, fairness and equality in the public procurement process.

"The use of undisclosed comparative standards, unexplained deductions under objective criteria, inconsistent marking and complete absence of recorded reasons strikes at the heart of transparency, fairness and equality in public procurement. Therefore, exclusion of a lower bidder on the basis of an arbitrary evaluation process is not merely an individual grievance but also raises concerns of public interest under Article 14 of the Constitution," the high court said.

The technical evaluation processes are set aside, the high court said. "Consequently, the award of tender in favour of the private respondents shall also stand nullified," the court said.

Calcutta HC refuses Mamata faction interim nod to operate bank accounts frozen by ED

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Monday refused the Mamata Banerjee faction of the Trinamool Congress interim permission to operate three of the party's bank accounts frozen by the Enforcement Directorate (ED).

The ED froze the three bank accounts of the Trinamool Congress with balances amounting to ₹440.42 crore in connection with its probe based on an FIR lodged by the state police in alleged dishonest financial dealings, unlawful collection of money, and routing of suspected funds through certain bank accounts of the party.

Justice Krishna Rao had on



July 13 reserved the interim order on the prayer after arguments by the parties in the matter were concluded.

According to officials, the Enforcement Directorate's preliminary investigation found that about ₹160 crore was transferred from the TMC's bank accounts to Carewell Aviation India Pvt. Ltd. and its related entity between April 2023 and June 2026.

The company is alleged to have further routed ₹82.96 crore (between 2023 and 2026) to another newly incorporated entity. It was found that a "significant" amount was transferred to this entity. Out of this, ₹112 crore was used for purchasing an Embraer Legacy 600 business jet and an AgustaWestland 109SP helicopter, the officials said.

2020 Delhi riots: SC stays HC relief to Devangana Kalita

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday stayed an order of the Delhi High Court, which permitted Delhi riots-accused Devangana Kalita to inspect unrelayed-upon documents in the alleged larger conspiracy case related to the 2020 riots.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi issued notice to Kalita on a plea filed by the Delhi Police challenging the June 5 high court order. "You will not conclude your arguments even in 10 years, and then you say there is delay in trial," the bench observed orally.

Additional Solicitor General SV Raju, appearing for the Delhi Police,

submitted that Kalita is not entitled to any document until charges are framed. "They can't ask for any other document. What is the purpose of inspection at this stage?" Raju asked.

Kalita's lawyer referred to a Supreme Court judgment and said the list of documents that are not relied on must also be furnished prior to framing of the charge. After hearing the parties, the Supreme Court bench issued notice to Kalita and stayed the Delhi High Court order.

The matter will now be heard after two weeks. On June 5, the high court had lifted its earlier stay on framing of charges in the alleged larger conspiracy case related to the



2020 riots and allowed the trial court to pass a final order.

The high court had vacated the court's order while dismissing Kalita's plea seeking direction to the

police to provide her certain videos and WhatsApp chats in relation to the case. The court, however, allowed a separate petition by Kalita and permitted her to inspect unrelayed-upon documents in the UAPA (Unlawful Activities Prevention Act) case.

Kalita had moved high court in 2023, claiming that Delhi Police had commissioned certain persons to record the February 2020 protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act and National Register of Citizens, and the footage should be supplied to her before the trial court proceeds to hear the arguments as it would show that she was protesting peacefully. Besides the video footage, she had also sought the

"entire WhatsApp chat" of a group, alleging that "selective extracts" were being used against the petitioner.

In the judgment, the court stated that all evidence being relied upon by the prosecution, along with the chargesheet, has already been provided to Kalita, along with the entire footage of the riots relevant to her.

The high court had said that only the communication, information, chats of police officials' groups and WhatsApp groups that are neither relied upon nor relevant, have not been shared with the petitioner as they may contain sensitive information or privileged communication that cannot be disclosed.

SC reduces punishment for rape convict citing reform possibility

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday reduced the sentence of a man convicted in a 2016 rape case from life imprisonment to 20 years in jail with benefit of remission, saying there was a possibility of reformation as the offence was committed when he was 25.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and Augustine George Masih noted that the man had no criminal antecedents and has maintained a good conduct in jail.

"In the present case, the appellant convict has no criminal antecedents; was of only 25 years when the offence was committed; given the young age there is a possibility of reformation.

"The State has neither brought on record anything to show that the same would not be possible, nor has it contravened the statement made on behalf of the appellant that in the nearly ten years (including remission) that he has been convicted, he has maintained a good conduct," the bench said.

The trial court had sentenced the man to rigorous imprisonment for the remainder of his natural life and also directed him to pay a fine of ₹25,000 to the victim. This decision was upheld by the Delhi High Court.

In this case, a call was received at I P Estate police station, New Delhi, alleging that two accused persons had committed rape on the victim. The victim at night-time took a rickshaw from



the Delhi railway station on the assurance that the driver would drop her off at her home but instead of doing so, he took her to a deserted place where another person was already present and they proceeded to commit the offence of rape. An FIR was registered on September 7, 2016.

The top court said it cannot lose sight of the fact that the offence is heinous and is not only against the victim but against the society at large.

"Despite much evolution, sociologically and psychologically, to break away from the chains of patriarchal thought, incidents such as these are only continuing unabashedly.

"Various amendments have been brought in over the years in the law, and while they may have had positive impact to some extent, the urgency to root out such offences cannot be simmered down even for a bit till these incidents are recorded only in history and are viewed with collective disdain," the bench said.



the sanctioned plan, while the authorities alleged that the structure had been built on land falling within a pond area.

The counsel urged the bench to grant immediate protection in view of the ongoing demolition.

The CJI declined to grant an urgent hearing or any interim relief.

Making it clear that the apex court would not enter-

tain the matter at the first instance, the CJI said the petitioner should pursue the appropriate remedy before the high court concerned. "Even if it is completely dismantled today, I will not...," the CJI said.

The CJI also expressed concern over the growing tendency of litigants to bypass high courts and seek urgent intervention directly from the apex court.

Kerala: Man sentenced to death in 2025 Nenmara double murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Palakkad

A court in Kerala on Monday sentenced a 61-year-old man to death in the sensational 2025 Nenmara double murder case.

Palakkad Additional Sessions Judge Kenneth George sentenced Chenthamara to death and imposed a fine of ₹20 lakh for murdering his neighbour Sudhakaran and his mother, Lakshmi, at Pothundi near Nenmara on January 27, 2025. The court convicted Chenthamara under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for murder and Section 126(2) for wrongful restraint.

Holding that the case fell



under the "rarest of rare" category, the court observed that the convict had murdered multiple members of the same family. Chenthamara had earlier been arrested for the 2019 murder of Sudhakaran's wife, Sajitha, whom he allegedly blamed for his marital problems. After being released on bail

in January 2025 in the case, he murdered Sudhakaran and Lakshmi. Police arrested him shortly after the double murder, following a massive manhunt, and he was later lodged in the Malampuzha sub-jail.

In the Sajitha murder case, a court had earlier sentenced Chenthamara to double life imprisonment.

The author is an alumnus of IIM Ahmedabad and Professor of Practice at IILM University, Gurugram with an interest in AI, Technology and Strategy



Assam Minister Pijush distributes MMUA cheques to beneficiaries

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Assam Minister for Agriculture, Irrigation, and Parliamentary Affairs Pijush Hazarika on Monday distributed Mukhyamantri Mahila Udyamita Abhiyaan (MMUA) cheques to 22,818 beneficiaries in Dhing, Nagaon.

The Minister stated that this is not only ten thousand rupees but an empowering tool for the women members of society to earn a livelihood and achieve economic independence. The Minister urged the beneficiaries to properly utilize the ₹10,000 seed money to set up businesses and become eligible to receive subsequent payments of ₹25,000 and ₹50,000 under the MMUA.

Minister Hazarika also spoke about welfare initiatives like PMAY houses, improved road infrastructure, free rations to poor families and free admission to schools and colleges under the present Central and State Governments.

He highlighted how all encompassing development has been ushered in by the State government led by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma. He also announced that distribution of free rations would be restarted from next month. He emphasised that the present Government is unbiased in giving benefits to people, cutting across linguistic and religious divides, and no area will be left untouched by development measures.

He further spoke about how flood protection measures have helped people in



the Dhing constituency cultivate two or more crops. Stating that poor, meritorious students have got government jobs under the present government, Minister Hazarika asserted that corruption in the recruitment process during the earlier Government's tenure has been completely eradicated. Sharing his vision for the Agriculture Department, Minister Hazarika urged the people to take up farming to contribute to Assam's economic development. He assured the farmers of all possible help from both the Agriculture and Irrigation departments.

MLAs Mehbub Mukhtar and Rupak Sarma, along with the DC of Nagaon, were also present at the meeting.

Later, the Minister attended a programme at Bhomoraguri and distributed land pattas to 81 families of the Nagaon-Batadrava constituency. He also distributed MMUA cheques to a few beneficiaries. The Minister said that those who received land pattas would now also be eligible for farmer registration, which would provide them with a unique ID. This registration will make them eligible to receive benefits under Government schemes.

Income tax department short of 26,997 officers, support staff

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Income Tax Department is running short of 26,997 officers and support staff as of January 1, 2026, Parliament was informed on Monday.

"The vacancies in Group A, B&C in the Income Tax Department as on January 1, 2026, are 26,997. Occurrence and filling up of vacancies is a continuous process," Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said in a written response to the Lok Sabha.

As and when vacancies arise, such vacancies are filled regularly in accordance with the terms of the mode of recruitment prescribed in the relevant recruitment rules, namely direct recruitment through UPSC/SSC or through promotion as applicable, it added.

Further, the introduction of the New Income Tax Act, 2025, has resulted in a landmark development to simplify language, remove



obsolete provisions and consolidate & restructure provisions, it said.

Measures have been taken to strengthen and modernise the tax administration by leveraging information and digital technology for ease of filing, faster processing of returns, data analytics and faceless assessments, he said.

Replying to another question, Chaudhary said 11 individuals have been declared as Fugitive Economic Offenders under the provisions of the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act, 2018 (FEOA) since 2024.

Properties worth ₹1,303.16 crore have been confiscated under the provisions of the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act, 2018, pertaining to such offenders since 2024, he added.

Out of the above-mentioned fugitives, Red Notice has been published against 8 individuals, and extradition requests have been sent in respect of 4 individuals who were located, he said.

Moreover, he said 12 Mutual Legal Assistance Requests (MLAR) have also been sent. He further said that the necessary steps have been taken by the government to restructure the confiscated property to the legitimate victims of such economic offences.

So far, he said, the Directorate has successfully restored properties valued at approximately ₹73,015.03 crore to victims or legitimate claimants, resulting in restitution of ₹15,262.30 crore and ₹32,677.97 crore during FY 2024-25 and 2025-26, respectively.

Moreover, he said that during the FY 2026-27 till date, an amount of ₹9,873.11 crore has been restituted.

As per the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) Balance of Payments (BoP) statistics, he said, net private transfers, mainly representing remittances by Indians employed overseas, increased from \$124.6 billion in 2024-25 to \$144.8 billion in 2025-26.

IOB Q1 profit surges 49% to ₹1,659 crore



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned lender Indian Overseas Bank (IOB) on Monday reported a 49.3 per cent year-on-year jump in net profit to ₹1,659 crore in the three months ended June 2026, driven by improved asset quality. The bank had earned a net profit of ₹1,111 crore in the corresponding quarter last year.

Total income rose to ₹10,938 crore during the April-June period from ₹8,866.47 crore a year earlier, the bank said in a stock

exchange filing. The bank's asset quality improved, with Gross Non-Performing Assets (GNPA) dropping to 1.33 per cent for the June quarter of FY27 from 1.97 per cent a year earlier. Similarly, net NPA eased to 0.18 per cent from 0.32 per cent.

Further, provisions were at ₹834 crore in the quarter under review mostly unchanged from ₹844 crore a year earlier but lower than ₹1,006 crore in the March quarter. Shares of IOB were trading 4.11 per cent higher at ₹35.2 on the BSE in the afternoon trade.

Canara HSBC Life Insurance Q1 profit rises 20% to ₹28 cr



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company on Monday reported 20 per cent increase in net profit at ₹28 crore for the quarter ended June 30, 2026, driven by higher premium collection. The insurer's net profit stood at ₹23 crore a year earlier.

The company's net premium income rose to ₹2,048 crore during June quarter FY27 from ₹1,653 crore a year ago, according to a stock exchange filing.

The assets under management (AUM) expanded by 14 per cent to surpass ₹49,683 crore. The Value of New Business (VNB) grew by 29 per cent to ₹124 crore in Q1 FY27, it said.

VNB is the present value of expected future earnings from new policies written during a specified period/fiscal and it reflects the additional value to shareholders expected to be generated through the activity of writing new policies during a specified period. Solvency ratio of Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company listed earlier last year declined to 198 per cent as against 200 per cent in the same period a year ago.

Serving poor true tribute to Almast Babu Lal Badshah's ideals: Haryana CM Saini

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that the life of Almast Babu Lal Badshah Ji conveys the message of love, brotherhood, humanity and social harmony. He said Babu Lal Badshah Ji believed that where there is true love, there is no place for discrimination.

The Chief Minister was addressing the gathering while attending the 43rd Annual Three-Day Mela at Almast Babu Lal Badshah Ji's Darbar in Nakodar, Jalandhar, on Monday. The Gaddi Nashin of Almast Babu Lal Badshah Dargah Hans Raj Hans also attended the event.

CM Nayab Singh Saini said that it was a matter of immense privilege and pride for him to visit the sacred land of Nakodar, associated with Almast Babu Lal Badshah Ji. He described it as a blessing to have the opportunity to pay his respects at this holy shrine. He also expressed gratitude to the Sh. Hans Raj Hans for inviting him and extending a warm welcome.

The Chief Minister said that although Punjab and Haryana are two separate states, they share a common cultural heritage, Guru tradition and deep social bonds. He remarked that the two states are like two brothers from the same family and will always continue to



Haryana CM Saini being welcomed at Noor Mahal Divya Jyoti Jagriti Sansthan in Jalandhar on Monday. Former MP Sunita Duggal also present

move forward with the spirit of love, brotherhood and mutual harmony. He expressed the hope that just as Haryana is progressing steadily on the path of development, Punjab too would advance rapidly and further strengthen its position among the country's leading states. He also prayed to Almast Babu Lal Badshah Ji for the prosperity and well-being of both states and for the progress of the nation. CM Saini said that the Haryana Government, drawing inspiration from the teachings of Babu Lal Badshah Ji, is implementing several public welfare schemes for the benefit of the poor, the needy and underprivileged.

Former Member of Parliament Sunita Duggal, former Minister Aseem Goel, District President, Sardar Jagbir Singh Brar, and Sardar Gulab Singh Sandhu were also present on the occasion.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar
Engineering Department
Tender Notice
Tender Reference No. GNDU/ENGG/2026/07-04-05
The Engineering Department of Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar invites online bids for:-
(i) Renovation and Upgradation of various toilets (With Waterless Urinal and Other Water Conserving Fitting and Techniques) within Guru Nanak Dev University (Under RUSA 2.0) (ii) SITC of Old Number 6 Passenger Lift at Library Building.
Closing date & time: 04-08-2026 upto 04-00 pm
For details log onto www.aproc.punjab.gov.in
Note: Any Corrigendum/Addendum to the tender notice shall be published on the above website only.
24/26/12/2026-27/13417 Dated CHD :- 20/07/2026

INDAG
INDAG RUBBER LIMITED
(CIN: L74899DL1978PLC009038)
Regd. Office: 11, Community Centre, Saket, New Delhi -110017.
Ph. No. : 011-26963172/73; E-mail ID: info@indagrubber.com;
Website: www.indagrubber.com

NOTICE OF THE 47th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, DIVIDEND & RECORD DATE AND REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION
Notice is hereby given that the Forty-Seventh (47th) Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the Members of Indag Rubber Limited (the "Company") will be held on Wednesday, August 12, 2026 at 05:00 P.M. (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") facility including e-voting/ remote e-voting without the physical presence of the members at a common venue to transact the business(es) as set out in the Notice of 47th AGM dated June 22, 2026. The venue of the meeting shall be deemed to be the Registered Office of the Company.
In compliance with General Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated April 8, 2020, 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, the latest being 3/2025 dated September 22, 2025, by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India ("MCA's Circulars") and Circulars issued by the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI's Circulars") and in compliance with the provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations"), the Company has sent the Notice of 47th AGM and Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 on July 20, 2026 through electronic mode to all the members whose name appear in Register of Members as on July 10, 2026 and whose email addresses are registered with the Company/ Registrar to an Issue and Share Transfer Agent (RTA)/ Depository Participant(s) (DPs).
As per Regulation 36(1)(b) of the Listing Regulations, the letter mentioning the web-link including the exact path, where complete details of the AGM Notice and Annual Report are available, is being sent to those members(s) who have not registered their e-mail IDs with the Company/ RTA/ DPs.
The Notice of 47th AGM and Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 are also available on the website of the Company at www.indagrubber.com under the head 'Investors Relation'; on the website of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com; and on the website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com. Members can attend and participate in the ensuing AGM through VC/ OAVM only and such Members shall be reckoned for the purpose of quorum under Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

RECORD DATE AND DIVIDEND
The Board of Directors in their meeting held on May 28, 2026 had recommended a Final Dividend of Rs. 1.50/- per equity Share of face value of Rs. 2/- each. The Final Dividend, if approved by the Shareholders at the ensuing AGM, will be paid on or before September 10, 2026, only in electronic mode, to those Shareholders whose names appear in the Register of Members as on August 5, 2026, in respect of shares held in physical form, and to those beneficial owners whose names appear in the records furnished by NSDL/CDSL as on the close of business hours on August 5, 2026, in respect of shares held in dematerialized form. The Register of Members and Share Transfer books shall remain closed from Thursday, August 06, 2026 to Wednesday, August 12, 2026 (both days inclusive).

REMOTE E-VOTING
Pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and Regulation 44 of the SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015, the Company has availed services of National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) to provide Electronic Voting Facility to its members to cast their votes on all resolutions as set forth in the Notice convening 47th AGM. The voting rights of members shall be in proportion to their share of the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the cut-off date i.e., **Wednesday, August 5, 2026.**
The remote e-voting period commences from August 9, 2026 at 9:00 A.M. (IST) and will end on August 11, 2026 at 5:00 P.M. (IST). During this period, the shareholders may cast their votes electronically. The remote e-voting shall be disabled by NSDL thereafter. Those Shareholders, who shall be present in the AGM through VCI/OAVM facility and had not cast their votes on the Resolutions through remote e-voting and are otherwise not debarred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting systems during the AGM.
The shareholders who have already cast their votes by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend/participate in the AGM through VCI/OAVM but shall not be entitled to cast their votes again.
Any person who has acquired shares and become member of the Company after sending of AGM Notice in electronic form but before the cut-off date of August 5, 2026, may obtain their user ID and password for remote e-voting from the Company's RTA via e-mail at admin@skylineria.com or NSDL at evoting@nsdl.co.in. However, if the person is already registered with NSDL for remote e-voting then the existing user ID and password can be used for casting vote. A person who is not a member of the Company as on cut-off date i.e. Wednesday, August 5, 2026, should treat this Notice for information purpose only.
In case of any queries, members may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) and e-Voting user manual available at the download section of www.evoting.nsdl.com or call on 022-4886 7000 and 022- 2499 7000 or send a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in or contact Ms. Pallavi Mhatre, Senior Manager, National Securities Depository Limited, T301, 3rd Floor, Narman Chambers, G-Block, Plot C-32, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra East, Maharashtra - 400 051, at the designated email id evoting@nsdl.co.in who will also address the grievances connected with voting by electronic means. Members may also write to the Company Secretary at info@indagrubber.com.
The Board of Directors has appointed Mr. Kanishk Arora of M/s Kanishk Arora & Co., Practicing Company Secretaries (FCS 9575; CP No. 13253), as the Scrutinizer for conducting remote e-voting in a fair and transparent manner.
The details of the said meeting are also available on the website of the Company at www.indagrubber.com and the website of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com.

By order of the Board
For Indag Rubber Limited
Sd/-
Sonal Garg
Company Secretary
(ACS 24598)

Date: July 20, 2026
Place: New Delhi

DAILY SUDOKU
DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆
HOW TO SOLVE IT
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction - no maths involved.

SOLUTION (20.7.26)

7	2	5	3	8	9	6	4	1
3	1	4	7	5	6	8	2	9
6	8	9	4	1	2	5	7	3
4	3	6	2	9	7	1	8	5
8	7	1	5	4	3	2	9	6
9	5	2	8	6	1	4	3	7
2	6	3	1	7	8	9	5	4
1	4	8	9	3	5	7	6	2
5	9	7	6	2	4	3	1	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | JULY 21, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
		9					
10							
13		14					16
17							
20	21					22	23
24							
27							
30							31

ACROSS
1 Saucy in a novel way? (5)
6 New ideas to which actors are deaf (5)
9 One at the doctor's but without a complaint? (7)
10 Two ways to try for admission (5)
11 She's a setback for Aidan (5)
12 Singer given heart by English National Opera (5)
13 Removed from the rent book? (4,3)
15 Gardens by the river (3)
17 Neglect to order it (4)
18 Possibly green article to be found in groups (6)
19 It's tough with nothing in store (5)

DOWN
2 Would irregular soldiers fire at it? (6)
3 Rush to arrange out-of-the-way trips (6)
4 It's a sort of fever! (3)
5 Beast bringing wicked vice to the East End (5)
6 Irked at having done any wrong (7)
7 Sunny sort of celebrity? (4)
8 Motoring club? (6)
12 Teacher makes that impatient noise, a bit out of sorts (5)
13 Is such a brush one of a set? (5)
14 One competitor of several in a rail system (5)
15 Food to bake fresh, note (5)

SOLUTION (20.7.26)

ACROSS	24, Soundly	DOWN	20, Blitch
3, Ho-i-st	26, Crated	21, To bat	21, Nomad
8, Got up	29, Cue (queue)	2, Rub-iron	23, Pledged
10, Ought	31, Ho-Dies	4, Oval	24, Seps-me
11, Bob	32, Peddles	5, Sort-I.e.	25, Out (rev)
12, Ba-I-rd	34, Paris	6, Tu-D-or	27, Races
13, Ca-pit-ol	35, Gus	7, Sheet	28, Te-P-id
15, Towel	36, D-EN-IM	9, To-p	28, Te-P-id
18, Co-y	37, Medoc	12, Boyhood	30, B-esom
19, P-rate	38, Dekko	14, Tow	32, Pin-k
21, Now-Here		16, W-ally	33, Lud
22, Iron		17, L-ends	
23, P-iod		19, Pra-N-cs	

BRIEFLY

How Ferran Torres scored WC-winning goal for Spain



Ferran Torres delivered Spain the winning goal at the World Cup with a play made possible by two of the team's best players and two who substituted into the final against Argentina on Sunday.

Until that point, Spain put 11 shots on net and could not crack opposing goalkeeper Emiliano "Dibu" Martinez. "We had many chances," Spain coach Luis de la Fuente said. "But Dibu was nothing short of exceptional."

The teams had played 105 minutes, and Spain looked to get a big advantage when Enzo Fernandez was sent off in regulation stoppage time with his second yellow card.

Still, playing 11 men against 10, Spain was unable to capitalize on any chances through the first half of extra time, including a disallowed goal when the referee ruled that Mikel Merino stepped on one of Argentina defender Nicolas Otamendi's feet prior to Nico Williams putting the ball into the net.

The buildup to the goal: With the score 0-0 coming out of the midway point of extra time, Spain got the ball at midfield. Argentina, playing shorthanded, put up very little resistance.

FIFA President's Infantino World Cup journey in figures



Multiple flights in a single day. Nearly 60,000 miles. More than 100 hours aloft.

FIFA President Gianni Infantino got some serious air time over the course of the 2026 World Cup, the tournament's most far-flung edition ever. He crisscrossed North America for matches, meetings and other appearances during the competition, which took place in three countries, 16 cities and four time zones, and ended with Sunday's final in New Jersey.

To track his travels, The Associated Press analyzed flight logs for a private business jet used by Infantino in recent years, along with photos taken by AP photographers and images posted on Instagram by FIFA and the head of world soccer's governing body himself.

The analysis shows that by the time Spain defeated Argentina for the world title, he flew far enough to circle the planet almost 2 1/2 times.

Access to a Gulfstream G650 jet from the fleet of the Qatari government made Infantino's prodigious jet-setting possible. The aircraft is operated by the private charter division of Qatar Airways, a World Cup sponsor.

They sing, they dance, WC fans from Argentina, Spain spent cash at final

DAN GELSTON
East Rutherford (USA)

Tom Cruise gamely tried to deliver a speech at the World Cup about how soccer was some sort of global unifier and great players had crossed oceans and borders, and, well, what was the rest?

It was about mission impossible to hear the actor over the cacophony of bells and whistles and drums that served as the house band for all the joyous singing and clapping among the Argentine and Spanish fans who traveled thousands of miles — and spent thousands and thousands more in tickets, beers and, yes, wigs — to watch the World Cup final.

No exorbitant ticket price was too high to possibly say goodbye to Lionel Messi, playing in likely his last World Cup game.

"Money comes back," Argentina fan Manuel Lopez Maccotta said. "This is once in a lifetime. You're seeing the best player in the world in his last World Cup. Money is worthless compared to this."

Maccotta and one of his friends traveled from Buenos Aires to New Jersey to watch Spain's 1-0 win over Argentina on Ferran Torres' goal in extra time on Sunday.

The ticket price?: "Almost 10K in American money," Maccotta said.

The \$18 beer he was in line to buy suddenly seemed like chump change compared to the hot game ticket.

His friend Santiago Burcaco got off easy at \$5,000 for his ticket.

"I bought the ticket before the World Cup final," he said.



BRIAN MAHONEY
East Rutherford (USA)

Kylian Mbappe kept the Golden Boot award and Spain wouldn't let Lionel Messi get anything else.

Shortly after winning the World Cup title Sunday, the Spaniards claimed all three individual player awards, keeping Messi from leaving with any more personal hardware.

Rodri won the Golden Ball as the tournament's best player, Unai Simon won the Golden Glove for the top performance by a goalkeeper, and Pau Cubarsi won the Best Young Player Award, beating out fellow 19-year-old teammate Lamine Yamal.

Messi was hoping to win a record-extending third Golden Ball, adding to his 2014 and 2022 honors. He's already the only player to win the award multiple times since it was first given

Mbappe wins another Golden Boot, and Spain's Rodri gets Golden Ball

in 1978, and sparking Argentina's run to a second straight final at age 39 gave him a strong case for another.

But the award went to Rodri for captaining Spain's run to its second World Cup title after the Manchester City midfielder struggled early after returning in May 2025 from knee surgery that sidelined him eight months.

"For me, it's been a very tough time. I just want the new generation to see my example as an opportunity to that if you go down, you can rise again," he said. "This is my philosophy my entire life. Of course, sometimes things go well, things go wrong. But always the positive."

Rodri had no goals or assists in the tournament, but he was critical to Spain's possession-heavy style of play. He completed more passes than anyone (753) with 94% accuracy. He was involved in 1,803 plays, according to FIFA stats, nearly 200 more than anyone else in

this World Cup. "I heard that at the beginning of the tournament I wasn't able to play, now that I recovered my shape, I tried not to listen too much," Rodri said on the eve of the final. "I've always been confident of myself. I think one of the big parts of my game is trying to replicate this accuracy in terms of passing and being very safe with the ball."

Rodri became just the 11th man to win the World Cup, the UEFA Champions League and the Ballon d'Or - the biggest individual award in



soccer, awarded for soccer's player of the year, which he won in 2024 when Spain won the European title.

FIFA says the Golden Ball was awarded to the best player in the tournament based on a ranking compiled by the FIFA Technical Study Group. Messi won the Silver Ball and Mbappe the Bronze Ball.

Simon set a record with his seven shutouts in the tournament, allowing just one goal in eight games. Cubarsi, the Barcelona defender, helped anchor Spain's record-setting defensive effort and had the most completed passes in the final.

Cubarsi and Yamal became the first teenagers to start for the winning team in the World Cup final since Mbappe was also 19 when France won the 2018 title. He won that young player award that year.

Mbappe totaled 10 goals and four assists this time for a France team that finished fourth. Messi ended up with eight goals and four assists after going without a goal or an assist Sunday for the first time in his last 12 World Cup games.

Ferran Torres' goal of a lifetime gives Spain glory

TIM REYNOLDS
East Rutherford (USA)

This is how good Spain was at the World Cup: Not even Lionel Messi had any answers. And when it was over, Spain walked off with the trophy. Messi simply walked off in tears.

Spain is back atop the soccer world for a second time, after Ferran Torres' first goal of this year's World Cup — unquestionably the goal of his life — gave his country a 1-0 win over now-dethroned champion Argentina in the final on Sunday. "It was a goal scored by 47 million people," Torres said, referring to Spain's population.

Maybe not by them — but certainly for them.

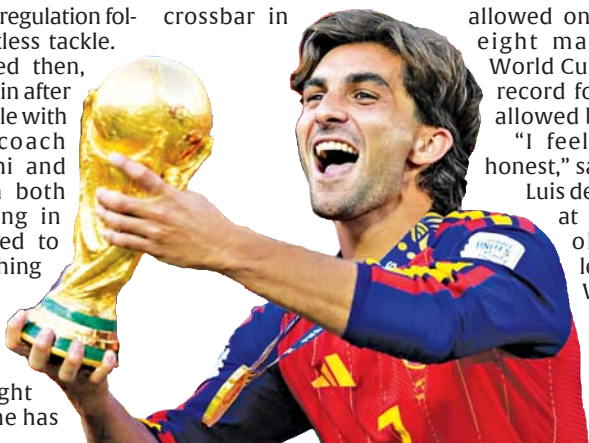
The goal came with Argentina down to 10 men after Enzo Fernandez was sent off late in regulation following a reckless tackle. Tempers flared then, and flared again after the final whistle with Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni and players from both sides engaging in what appeared to be some pushing and shoving.

In the end, Spain denied Messi a second straight title in what he has



indicated was his final World Cup match. Torres, a second-half substitute, pounced on a bouncing ball in the box and used his left foot to bury a shot just under the crossbar in

the 106th minute. From there, the airtight defense that dominated opponents throughout the tournament came through one final time. Spain — which also won the title in 2010 — allowed only one goal in eight matches in this World Cup run, setting a record for fewest goals allowed by a champion. "I feel pride, to be honest," said Spain coach Luis de la Fuente, who at 65 is now the oldest man to lead a team to a World Cup title. "Accompanying them on this journey is an honor."



Martinez plays cool in net, even as teammates turn reckless in final



DAN GELSTON
East Rutherford (USA)

Emiliano Martinez was cool as could be in goal, even as impatience and frustration brewed among his fiery Argentine teammates. Playing with a broken finger, he broke a World Cup final record for saves. The star goalkeeper just couldn't hold up after Argentina's unyielding, ruthless aggression steered La Albiceleste into a red card and left them a man down in extra time.

Spain's Ferran Torres smashed the ball past Martinez for his first goal of the World Cup to make it 1-0 in the 106th minute, enough on Sunday to send the team past Lionel Messi and Argentina for its first title

since 2010. Martinez, the World Cup-winning keeper from 2022, again used his imposing 6-foot-5 frame to stand tall with a record 11 saves and kept Argentina's bid for a second straight World Cup title alive.

His teammates spent much of the match chasing Spain around the pitch. And while Argentina's pugnacious style served it well rallying from deficits throughout this tournament, it backfired Sunday.

The first sign of trouble came when Leandro Paredes nearly earned two yellow cards on one play. Officials missed him shoving Rodri in the back in

the 52nd minute, but he was carded for pushing down Dani Olmo during the testy confrontation that followed.

Enzo Fernandez's frustration proved more costly. He got a first yellow card for dissent arguing a possible foul call in the 82nd minute. He was sent off with another yellow 11 minutes later for a reckless play that sent Spain defender Pau Cubarsi cartwheeling into the air.



Messi can conjure no more magic as crown passes from Argentina to Spain

RONALD BLUM
East Rutherford (USA)

Lionel Messi could conjure no more magic. Twenty years after his World Cup debut and a career that lifted him above Pele and Diego Maradona as soccer's greatest player, at 39 he could not will Argentina to become the first repeat champion in more than a half-century.

Spain outplayed the Albiceleste from the opening whistle at MetLife Stadium, where the overwhelming majority of 80,663 were hoping for a recordation. Ferran Torres scored 37 seconds into the second extra-time period, lifting Spain to a 1-0 victory and its second World Cup title.

Instead of Messi becoming a two-time champion, the crown passed. He fought back tears and had a look of misery as he and teammates faced applauding and bowing Argentina fans at the stadium's south end while Spanish stars lifted the trophy on a podium at the center stripe.

After leading Argentina to victory in the 2022 final against France, sandwiched between consecutive Copa America championships, Messi could only bow his head, grimace and put hands on hips as Spain's Lamine Yamal, less than a week past his 19th birthday and projected as the sport's next big thing, ran to embrace Torres after the goal.

"I hope that everyone feels proud of him, of what he's achieved because he's the best football player ever stepping

foot on a pitch," Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni said.

Spain's dominance was thorough in the final and throughout the World Cup as they extended their unbeaten streak to 38 games, the longest by a European team.

La Furia Roja had a 20-2 advantage in shots, the second-largest difference in a World Cup final since stats exist since 1966, behind only West Germany outshooting Argentina 23-1 in 1990, according to Opta. They out-passed Argentina 845-433.

They conceded just one goal the entire tournament, the fewest by a World Cup champion, and scored 14 while compiling a 145-45 advantage in shots. Goalkeeper Unai Simon totaled 10 saves over eight games — Argentina's Emiliano Martinez had 11 in the final alone. When Messi left European soccer for MLS three years ago after four Champions League medals and 12 league titles with Barcelona and Paris Saint-Germain, some speculated he would be another retiree moving to Florida.

Instead, he won a Major League Soccer title with Miami and led Argentina back to the final with eight goals and four assists. He has played in a record 34 World Cup games over six tournaments and boosted career goals total to 21, the record until France's Kylian Mbappe scored twice in Saturday's third-place game to surpass him to 22.



Rohit hasn't told us anything about retirement, says skipper Shubman Gill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

India skipper Shubman Gill says senior star Rohit Sharma has not spoken to him about his international future which has been a subject of intense speculation for the past few days.

Before the third ODI at Lord's on Sunday, in which Rohit smashed a majestic hundred albeit in a losing cause, rumours had swirled that the match would be his last for India. But BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia issued a firm denial.

The 39-year-old Rohit, who only plays the 50-over format now, eventually silenced his critics by becoming the first and the oldest Indian batter to score an ODI hundred at Lord's even as the team lost by 27 runs. Gill was asked whether the 'Hitman' had intimated anything to him about his future. "I mean, we have not had a chance (to speak to him). He's (Rohit) not told us anything. I think it's all out in the media. But there has not been any discussion like that," Gill said.

Gill was all praise for

Rohit's 138 off 110 balls and the manner in which he paced his innings that had 17 fours and five sixes. "I think the way Rohit Bhai paced the innings, it was great. Most of the time I was on the non-striker end watching. The conversation was mostly that if we keep the wickets in hand, then only



138 runs
110 balls
17 fours, 5 sixes



there will be a chance to chase such a big score.

"In Powerplay, we were talking that whether to go to hit or not, but we have seen that hitting with a new ball is not that easy. I think the way he paced his innings, and then the way he accel-

erated after reaching 70, it was great to see," he said.

Why no Kuldeep Yadav? Gill explains: Gill and coach Gautam Gambhir received a lot of flak for ignoring Kuldeep Yadav across all three games whereas England used multiple spinners to good effect.

Asked why Kuldeep wasn't played, Gill admitted that in hindsight, it seemed that two spinners could have been played on this track.

"So the matches that we played prior to this, we had seen the wickets get a little bit slower. When we were bowling and when Axar bhai was bowling, it didn't look like the wicket will get that slow, but when they (England) came into bowl, it did look like the wicket got a tad bit slower as the game went on," Gill said.

Also Gill said that whenever Indian spinners bowled, it seemed as if they were going on defensive. "Whenever spinners came in to bowl, we felt like we kind of had to go into defensive route whenever the fast bowlers were bowling, it felt like something was happening. And that was thought process behind not playing an extra spinner," he reasoned.



India records 78 doping cases till July 15; Punjab, UP at top: Sports Minister



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India has recorded 78 doping cases till July 15 this year with Uttar Pradesh and Punjab accounting for the biggest share of 13 violations each so far, Sports Minister Manuskh Mandaviya revealed on Monday in response to a query in Lok Sabha. After BJP MP Sambit Patra posed a query on the number of athletes who have tested positive for banned substances during the last three years, Mandaviya, in a written response, said 78 Adverse Analytical Findings (AAFs) have been recorded so far in 2026.

"These athletes have been banned from the Sports activities in accordance with the National Anti-Doping Rules, 2021. The sanctions, as determined by the Anti-Doping Disciplinary Panel (ADDP) include disqualification of results, forfeiture of medals/prizes, period of ineligibility from participation in sports, and other consequences as prescribed under the WADA Code 2021," the Minister stated.

In state-wise list of AAFs, it was revealed that after Uttar Pradesh and Punjab, Madhya Pradesh threw up the highest number of dope offenders — 11 — this year, followed by Karnataka, which had nine cases.

In 2023, India reported 213 doping violations, which increased to 260 in 2024 before the number declined sharply to 131 in 2025. No dope violations have been found so far this year among athletes representing Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Goa, Himachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, Meghalaya and Sikkim.

The Minister then listed the awareness initiatives that have been undertaken to promote clean sports.

"...the Government is implementing a comprehensive and sustained anti-doping awareness programme through NADA in accordance with the World Anti-Doping Code and International Standard for Education," he said.

Yuvraj wants clarity on Ro-Ko; concerned about lack of chances for Yashasvi Jaiswal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The spotlight seems fixed on Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli but former India all-rounder Yuvraj Singh says he is more concerned about Yashasvi Jaiswal at this point as the young opener waits on sidelines despite scoring two hundreds in last three ODI appearances. Speaking on 'JioStar', Yuvraj stressed on the need for clear communication between the team management and Rohit and Kohli about their future. He then urged the Indian think tank to "back them all the way" if the plan is to have them at next year's ODI World Cup in South Africa, Namibia and Zimbabwe.

"More than Virat and Rohit, my concern is that Yashasvi Jaiswal is not starting. If the World Cup comes and he hasn't had enough game time, he's



suddenly going to feel the pressure," Yuvraj told 'JioStar'.



Rohit silenced retirement speculation with a blazing 110-ball 138 against England in the third ODI at Lord's, while Kohli also looked in fine touch with successive fifties in the series that India lost 1-2 here on Sunday.

"You need to have that clarity from the coach, captain and selectors, whoever it is," he said. "I have been in that position, which Rohit and Virat find themselves in. So, it's not fair for us to judge whether they should play. It's the team management, the coach and the selectors who have to decide that."

"If you want them to play the WC, you have to tell them, 'Guys, we want you to play the World Cup. We are backing you all the way. Go out there and be yourselves. There is no stress that tomorrow, if you don't have a good series, that you're not going to be in the team.'"

All Indian women boxers capable of winning gold at CWG: Head coach Nieva

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ New Delhi

Every Indian woman boxer heading to the Commonwealth Games has the ability to win gold, head coach Santiago Nieva said, expressing confidence that the team can better its medal haul from the previous edition in Birmingham.

The Indian women pugilists have enjoyed a successful run on the international circuit over the past year, winning medals at the World Cups, World Championships and Asian Championships.

"We know we have a strong team. And we have set a high bar with expectations to do our best," Nieva said. "If



we look at the results from this year, not only this year, even from the World Cup finals last year and onwards, most of our women boxers have won gold or maybe silver in the tournaments. (PTI)

Gave away lot of runs in last 3 overs: Gill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

India captain Shubman Gill blamed his team's inability to stem the flow of runs at the death after England amassed 388, saying the hosts' late assault ultimately proved decisive in the visitors' 27-run defeat in the third ODI on Sunday.

Reflecting on the turning point, Gill said India remained firmly in the contest until the closing stages of England's innings, before an expensive finish with the ball swung the game decisively in the hosts' favour.

"We were right in the game until the 45th over (when England batted). Gave away a lot of runs in the last three overs. That's where the game went away from us," Gill said at the

Shubman Gill concerned with players reporting unfit after every few games



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

India's ODI skipper Shubman Gill has criticised the injury breakdown of his bowlers after "every second or third game", questioning whether they are taking their fitness seriously with World Cup coming up next year.

The Indians went down 1-2 to England in a three-match ODI series, losing by 27 runs in the deciding third game on Sunday. Before the start of the series, two pace bowling all-rounders — Hardik Pandya and Nitish Reddy were ruled out due to injuries.

Budding bowling all-rounder Harshit Rana also sustained a hamstring tear during the T20I series, ruling

him out of the ODIs. In the second ODI, Washington Sundar complained of hamstring injury while Jasprit Bumrah developed an impact injury in the second game and missed the series-decider.

"Yes, absolutely," Gill admitted when asked if there are concerns about so many niggles.

"If you look at the squad, the first squad that we announced, out of that, at least five players did not play this match. So one player gets injured, you try to play a different combination. There are two players, a different combination. But I think after every match, if a player is missing, somewhere we are missing a few tricks," Gill put forth his point very clearly.



post-match presentation ceremony. "We thought if we had wickets in hand after 40 overs, we would be in the game. At the same time, we didn't want to be too far behind. After the powerplay we tried to play at 6-6.5 runs per over and chase at 10 in the

last 10 overs," he said. Gill drew encouragement from Rohit Sharma's century, saying the senior opener once again demonstrated why he remains one of the world's finest ODI batters despite the surface becoming difficult for stroke-making.

New Zealanders wake to a new major champion, heap praise on Ryan Fox

STEVE MCMORRAN ■ Wellington

When Ryan Fox rolled in a 12-foot birdie putt on the 18th hole at Royal Birkdale to win the British Open by one shot, it was just past 5.30 a.m. in his homeland and the sun hadn't yet risen. Most New Zealanders woke Monday to a wintry morning and the news their small nation had its fourth major golf champion.

Those who followed Fox on television throughout the night were able to watch him lift the Claret Jug before heading bleary-eyed but happily to work.

Sir Bob Charles, who was New Zealand's first major winner and the first left-handed player to win a major when he won the British Open in 1963, is now 90 and watched Fox's foundry in replay at a more congenial hour. "I'm watching this in color. In my day, it was all black and white," Charles told



the New Zealand Herald newspaper of the TV coverage. "I'm watching every hole that he's playing. In my day, they only had about the last three or four holes."

Charles praised Fox for the pace at which he plays the game which goes against a modern tendency toward slow play. Fox hesitated for barely 30 seconds over the final putt that allowed him to join Charles, Michael Campbell and Lydia Ko as a major-

winner from New Zealand. "Ryan is a refreshing player," Charles told the Herald.

"He plays the way the game should be played, the way it used to be played and should be played. And that is: you get on with it, and you don't spend half an hour lining up every putt. "Let's hope that Ryan can be a great example of how the game should be played now, even when you're playing for, you know, \$100 million!" (AP)

Till I am playing, there will always be noise: Rohit Sharma

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Acutely aware but dismissive of the "noise" around his future in international cricket, veteran Indian batting star Rohit Sharma says he knows that speculation won't stop till he is playing but he would rather focus on scoring runs instead of fighting it.

With a facile 138 at the Lord's on Sunday, Rohit could not prevent India's 27-run loss didn't look his usual, possibly trying to mask the insult and hurt he must have felt.

"The noise, since I made my debut was there. Till I am going to stay here, it is always going to be there, so it doesn't really matter too much," the 39-year-old, who became the oldest Indian centurion and first from the country to score a ton in 50-over cricket, told BCCI.TV.

"What really matters is what I do on the field, try and contribute to the success of the team. That's where all my focus is. Let the noise be there, if there is no noise there is no fun. My job is inside, their job is outside,



that's how I look at it. "My job is with bat, come and play, represent my country, that's what I have been told to do since I made my debut, so that's what I am going to do," added the man, who is within touching distance of 12,000 ODI runs.

Under pressure, his 34th ODI ton was one of his best knocks in recent times. Rohit said he has always enjoyed playing in England.

New Zealand beats West Indies to clinch ODI cricket series

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bridgetown (Barbados)

Mark Chapman scored 80 and Mitchell Santner shepherded the tail to guide New Zealand to a tense one-wicket win over West Indies in the fourth one-day cricket international Sunday and to an unassailable 3-1 lead in the five-match series.

Santner was dropped with three runs needed and one wicket in hand, and last batter Jayden Lennox survived reviews for caught behind and lbw, before New Zealand edged past West Indies' modest total of 188 with 35 balls remaining.

Santner, the New Zealand captain, hit the winning runs from the first ball of the 45th over to finish 34 not out and to spoil West Indies' hopes of achieving a series-leveling victory to pay tribute to cricket great Garry Sobers.

"It was pretty chaotic, especially the ending," Santner said. "You try to chip off the total as



much as you can. Even partnerships of 10 or 15 at that stage was going a long way.

"It probably shouldn't have got that close but it was nice to get over the line."